

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PHILOSOPHY PAPER II | PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION 04

SOUL: IMMORTALITY, REBIRTH AND LIBERATION

SIX TERMS THAT MUST NEVER BE MERGED - WESTERN & INDIAN SOTERIOLOGY

IMMORTALITY -> REBIRTH -> LIBERATION : is each NECESSARY for the next? Buddhism = rebirth WITHOUT an immortal soul

WESTERN

immortality vs resurrection

- Plato (Phaedo): 4 a priori proofs
opposites - recollection - affinity - Form of Life
- soul naturally deathless, akin to Forms
- Kant: soul not a knowable substance
- Resurrection (Semitic): one life,
psychosomatic person raised by God
- identity: replica (Hick) / gap /
re-assembly (van Inwagen)
- Cullmann: immortality vs resurrection OPPOSED

INDIAN

eternal self vs no-self

- Vedanta: atman eternal -> moksha
Advaita identity | Visistadvaita communion
- Nyaya-Vaisesika: eternal self -> apavarga
- Samkhya-Yoga: purusa isolated -> kaivalya
- Jaina: eternal jiva -> kevala/siddhatva
asrava-bandha-samvara-nirjara
- Buddhism: anatman -> nirvana
rebirth as causal stream (flame-to-flame)
- karma + punarjanma drive the cycle

MOKSHA

Advaita: identity

APAVARGA

Nyaya: cessation

KAIVALYA

Samkhya: isolation

NIRVANA

Buddhism: cessation, no self

KEVALA

Jaina: perfected soul

Liberation is a family-resemblance term: identity, communion, isolation, cessation and perfected individuality - never one state

Provenance: Gita 2.22/2.23/18.66; Bhagavata 7.5.23; Samkhya-kanika 62-63/67-68; Yoga-sutra 1.24; Hick replica; Cullmann 1955; van Inwagen. Diacritics normalised on cover only.
Owns exactly 17 Philosophy of Religion PYQ parts, 2018-2025 (2:1:2:3:3:2:2:2). Six survival-terms kept distinct.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation - Learner-v2

Source-Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · philosophy-paper-ii-philosophy-of-religion-04 **Generation:** g2, 21 August 2026 · **Approval:** pending explicit topic approval **Evidence discipline:** exact doctrine, textual references and PYQ wording/year/marks are controlled by repository owners. Model answers are pedagogic, never official UPSC keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Direct verified topic-owned PYQs	17
Core diagnostic MCQs	40
Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
Total diagnostics	48
Original solved Mains models	3 (1 × 10, 1 × 15, 1 × 20)
Consolidated register parts	15 (A-O)
Approval	false

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Source-complete coverage ledger and answer-worthiness labels

[FACT] identifies retained repository doctrine or verified question data. **[INFERENCE]** identifies learner-facing organisation or judgement.

Source corpus	Final location	Retention decision
Canonical owner Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md	Basic and canonical apparatus in Practice	Every doctrine, distinction, textual reference, trap, route and answer rule retained through the layered package
Layered complete session, Simple Start + Core UPSC + Rapid Revision	Basic Learning Session	All ten logical subtopics retained in learner-first order
Layered complete session, Exam Application	PYQs and Answer Practice	All ten application layers retained before full solved practice
Layered complete session, Advanced layers	Optional Advanced	Every advanced layer moved intact after practice
Canonical exam apparatus	PYQs and Answer Practice	Foundational bank, drills, skeletons, routing, directive rules, verdict ladder and provenance discipline retained
Layered solved workbook	MCQs and Practice	All 17 full PYQs, 48 diagnostics and three original solved models retained
Layered package register	Consolidated Register Notes	Complete A-O register retained last
Philosophy of Religion advanced dossier	Optional Advanced	Identity criteria, memory objection, cessation/perfection and prārabdha refinements reconciled without fringe case literature

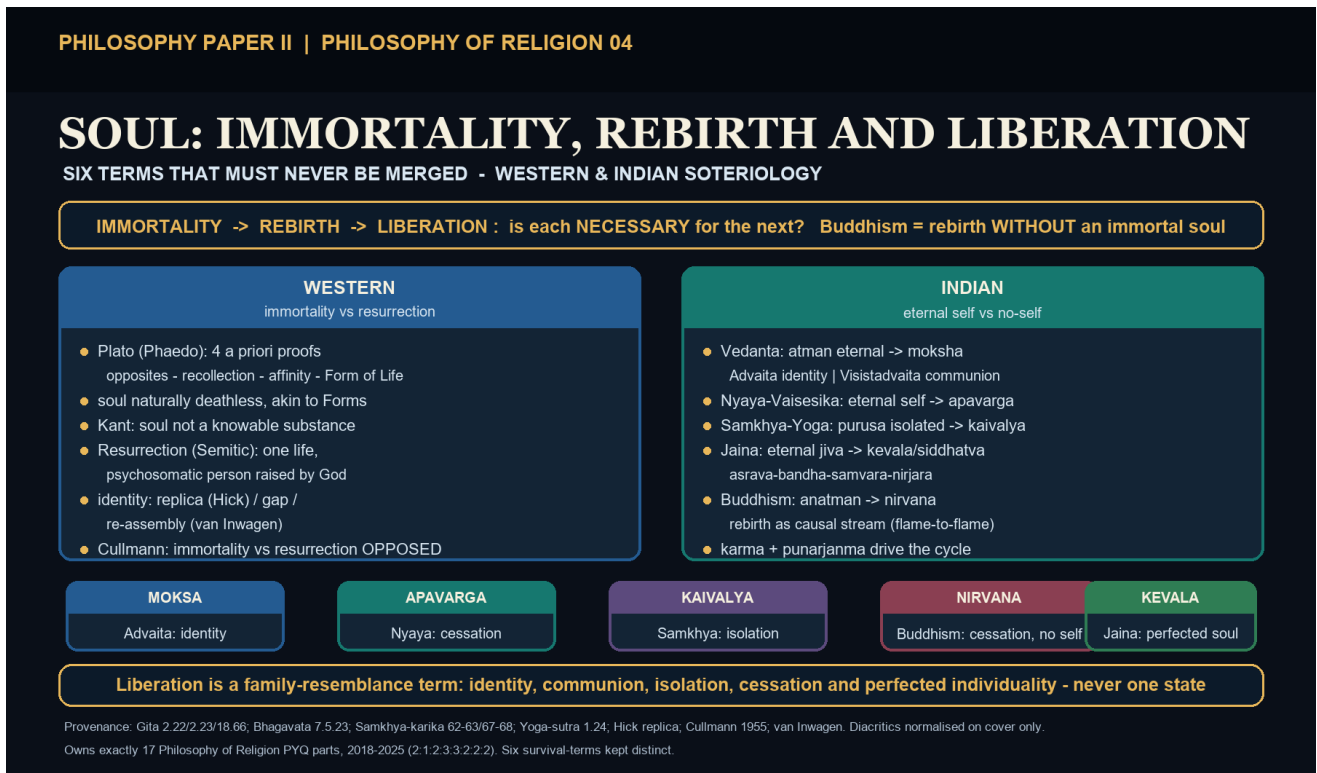
Visible learning labels. The six survival terms, Plato, karma-samsāra, Buddhist continuity, school-specific liberation, bhakti and direct PYQ routes are **CORE PAPER II**. Modal necessity, comparison, objection-reply and exact verdict

control are **CORE ANSWER**. Attributed book depth and bounded cross-links are **SUPPORTING**. Teleportation-style identity puzzles, dense resurrection metaphysics and second-order continuity disputes are **OPTIONAL ADVANCED**.

What not to over-study. Do not use paranormal reincarnation reports, modern brain-split catalogues or undisciplined mystical claims. Memorise the six-term distinction, each school's continuity-bearer and liberation terminus, one objection/reply, and the correct modal verdict.

Contemporary-link boundary

FACT: **Fact:** A fresh August 2026 search found ongoing scholarly work on personal identity and resurrection, but no sufficiently direct official Indian current-affairs development tied to this static syllabus clause. ANALYSIS: **Inference:** Current relevance is therefore conceptual rather than event-driven. No decorative current-affairs claim is forced into the teaching.



Six survival terms concept map

How to Use This Five-Layer Session

Every logical subtopic follows exactly:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	visual-first plain-language gateway
2. CORE UPSC	complete terminology, doctrine, argument, example and source grounding
3. ADVANCED	objections, replies, comparisons, interpretive issues and provenance cautions
4. EXAM APPLICATION	verified PYQ routes and 10/15/20-mark architecture
5. RAPID REVISION	traps, retrieval notes and links to the exact MCQ set

Source Audit and Contemporary-Link Boundary

- **Canonical doctrine source:** upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md (6,930 words), sliced verbatim into the CORE UPSC layers (each canonical teaching passage exactly once) and preserved again, in full, in the canonical apparatus block.
- **Supplementary book depth (attributed):** the local text-searchable **Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion** supplies verified Western analytic depth on resurrection and personal identity - Lynne Rudder Baker's "Death and the Afterlife" (four identity criteria; Origen "seed" / Augustine "statue" / Aquinas on bodily integrity;

Peter van Inwagen's three anti-reassembly arguments; Bernard Williams's duplication problem; H. H. Price's image-world), Paul J. Griffiths on Sankara's Advaita (*avidya* as the cause of beginningless *samsara*; *moksa* "not acquired but acknowledged"), and Philip L. Quinn contrasting Christian union-with-God and Buddhist *nirvana*. These are used only where actually present, always clearly marked BOOK.

- **Verified PYQs:** continuous local Philosophy of Religion Paper II bank, 2018-2025; this clause owns exactly **17** primary parts (2018:2, 2019:1, 2020:2, 2021:3, 2022:3, 2023:2, 2024:2, 2025:2). Indian Philosophy Paper I questions that merely mention *moksa* or soul are kept separate.
- **Six survival-terms kept distinct:** immortality (soul survives death), rebirth (karmic re-becoming), reincarnation (a substantial soul re-enfleshed), resurrection (one life, bodily re-constitution by God), and liberation (exit from the cycle) - which itself splits into *moksa* (identity/communion), *apavarga* (cessation), *kaivalya* (isolation), *nirvana* (blowing-out, no self) and *kevala/siddhatva* (perfected individuality). Merging any two loses half the marks.
- **Provenance discipline:** verse/karika/sutra numbers and attributions are transcribed from the canonical source; disputed ascriptions (the *Vivekacudamani*'s bhakti definition to Sankara personally) are flagged, never asserted; illustrations (flame-to-flame, potter's wheel, garment) are used as models, never as proofs.
- **Contemporary-affairs boundary (deliberate):** a live search found **no sufficiently direct, reliable official 2026 development** to anchor this static, syllabus-driven topic. No current-affairs anchor is forced and no institutional claim is invented.
- **Qdrant:** optional fallback only; not required for this canonical topic, and it never blocks the learning session.

Preservation note: the canonical doctrine is reorganised into layers, never compressed. Every doctrine, canonical verse/karika/sutra citation, numbered argument, objection/reply, comparison, corpus-depth delta, PYQ route, directive rule, graded verdict and provenance caution is retained; simplification means adding accessible gateways, not deleting complexity.

Learning Roadmap

Unit	Logical subtopic
1	The Six Survival-Terms and the Necessity Question
2	Immortality of the Soul: Plato's Four Proofs and the Western Critique
3	Rebirth: Karma, Samsara and the Buddhist Challenge
4	Buddhist Rebirth Without a Soul: Anatman and Causal Continuity
5	Liberation Across Schools: the Parity Bench
6	Vedantic Atman, Rebirth and Moksa: Advaita versus Visistadvaita
7	Jain Jiva and Bondage: the Karmic-Matter Ladder
8	Cessation and Isolation: Nyaya Apavarga, Advaita Jivanmukti and Samkhya-Yoga Kaivalya
9	Paths to Liberation: Bhakti, and the Jnana-Karma-Bhakti Question
10	Resurrection vs Rebirth vs Reincarnation; Inter-School Debates, Criticisms and Traps

The Six Survival-Terms and the Necessity Question

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

The whole syllabus item turns on refusing to treat six words as synonyms. Read this map first; everything else hangs on it.

SIX WORDS, SIX MEANINGS -- never swap them

IMMORTALITY	the soul does not die when the body dies
SURVIVAL	something of me continues after death
REBIRTH	re-becoming in a new life, driven by karma
REINCARNATION	a SOUL re-enters flesh (needs a substance)
RESURRECTION	ONE life; God raises the whole person again
LIBERATION	exit from the cycle itself (many names)

test chain: IMMORTALITY --> REBIRTH --> LIBERATION	

is each one NEEDED for the next?
 the shock: Buddhism has rebirth AND liberation with
 NO immortal soul at all

Think of six different bus routes that lazy speakers all call "the bus". If you board the wrong one you end up in the wrong city. In this topic, half the marks are lost simply by merging two of these terms. The examiner's favourite move is to ask whether one term is a *necessary condition* for the next.

MEMORY: I -> R -> L. Immortality, Rebirth, Liberation. Ask of each arrow: is the earlier term necessary, sufficient, or neither, for the later one?

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP ANALYSIS:

IMMORTALITY ---> REBIRTH ---> LIBERATION (is each necessary for the next?)		
(soul survives death)	(soul re-embodies per karma)	(freedom from the cycle)
┌-----┴-----┐		
WESTERN	INDIAN	
Plato: soul immortal (a priori proofs, Phaedo)	Vedānta: ātman eternal -> mokṣa (jīvanmukti/videhamukti)	
Christianity: resurrection	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika: soul eternal substance -> apavarga (release)	
	Jainism: jīva eternal -> kaivalya	
	Buddhism: NO permanent soul (anātman!) -> nirvāṇa	
	- rebirth WITHOUT a transmigrating self	

MEMORY: **Mnemonic - "I->R->L"**: Immortality -> Rebirth -> Liberation. The exam's favourite question: *is immortality of the soul a NECESSARY condition for rebirth / for liberation?* Buddhism is the great counter-example (rebirth **without** an immortal soul).

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Six terms, six meanings: immortality / survival / rebirth / reincarnation / resurrection / liberation. Never merge any two.
- The magic sentence: "immortality of a substantial soul is sufficient for rebirth but not necessary; what rebirth needs is a continuity-bearer."
- Liberation = family-resemblance term. Fix the exact term before you expound.

WRONG: Answering a "necessary condition" question with a description of rebirth. The examiner is buying a modal verdict, not a summary.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 1-4 in Part II.

Immortality of the Soul: Plato's Four Proofs and the Western Critique

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plato's Phaedo offers four separate arguments that the soul cannot die. Treat them as four branches, not one lump.

PLATO -- four a priori proofs (Phaedo)

=====

[1] OPPOSITES	living and dead arise from each other -> souls must persist between lives
[2] RECOLLECTION	we judge equal sticks by an Equality we never saw -> the soul knew it BEFORE birth
[3] AFFINITY	the soul is simple, invisible, like the Forms -> it does not decompose
[4] FORM OF LIFE	the soul essentially brings Life, so it cannot admit its opposite, death

bridge needed: pre-existence (1,2) is NOT yet survival;
 each proof must reach BOTH directions

critique: affinity/simplicity are ASSUMED; Kant --
 the soul is not a knowable substance

Plain version: Plato argues that because the soul is the kind of thing that is simple and life-giving, it is not the kind of thing that can fall apart or die. The Indian systems agree the self is eternal, but from very different premises.

MEMORY: Plato's four = O-R-A-F: Opposites, Recollection, Affinity, Form of Life.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

1. IMMORTALITY OF THE SOUL FACT:

- **Plato (Phaedo - 2023 PYQ) - a priori proofs:** FACT: 1. **Argument from Opposites (cyclical):** opposites come from opposites; living->dead and dead->living, so souls persist. 2. **Argument from Recollection (anamnesis):** learning = recollecting knowledge the soul had before birth -> soul pre-exists. 3. **Argument from Affinity:** the soul is simple, immaterial, akin to the eternal Forms -> indissoluble/immortal. 4. **Argument from the Form of Life:** the soul essentially participates in Life, so cannot admit its opposite (death).
- **Critique:** the affinity/simplicity claims are assumptions; Kant - the soul is not a knowable substance (paralogism). ANALYSIS:
- **Indian:** ātman (Vedānta), jīva (Jain), and the Nyāya self are **eternal** in their respective systems. The *Gītā* 2.23 uses the canonical image that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the embodied self. FACT:

8.1 Plato's immortality arguments

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: In the *Phaedo*, Plato presents the soul as pre-existent and akin to intelligible, non-composite reality, culminating in the claim that soul essentially brings life and cannot admit death.
- **Argument.** FACT: Cyclical argument: living and dead arise from each other. Recollection: grasp of equality exceeds sensory instances and indicates pre-natal acquaintance. Affinity: soul resembles invisible, stable Forms more than composite body. Final argument: what essentially participates in Life cannot receive its contrary.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Learning is recollection, likeness to the simple supports indestructibility, and essential predicates exclude contraries.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Pre-existence does not by itself prove post-mortem survival; each argument must bridge both directions.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Equal sticks never perfectly instantiate Equality, yet we judge their deficiency by a standard not derived from them alone.
- **Objection -> reply.** FACT: Simmias' harmony analogy makes soul dependent on body; Plato replies that soul governs body and recollection implies prior existence.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Four proofs: Opposites, Recollection, Affinity, Form of Life.
- Pre-existence (1,2) is not survival: flag the bridge.
- Kill-shot critique: simplicity is assumed; Kant -- no knowable substance.
- Simmias = harmony objection; Plato's reply = soul governs body.

WRONG: Blurring the four arguments into "Plato thought the soul is eternal". That caps you at the average band.

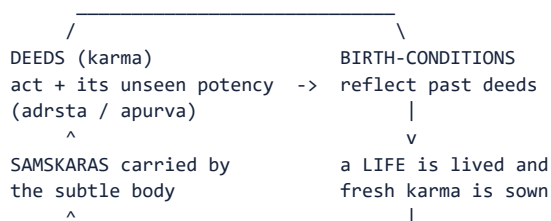
-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 5-8 in Part II.

Rebirth: Karma, Samsara and the Buddhist Challenge

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Rebirth is the wheel: deeds leave traces, traces shape the next birth, and the wheel turns until liberation stops it.

THE WHEEL OF KARMA AND REBIRTH (samsara)



\ _____ DEATH _____ /

three karmas: sancita (stored) | prarabdha (ripening now) | agami (future)

NOT fatalism: purusakara (effort) works within daiva
exit only by LIBERATION (knowledge / grace / discipline)

Plain version: karma is not fate. It is a moral book-keeping in which today's choices set tomorrow's starting conditions, and rebirth is simply the fact that the ledger runs longer than one lifetime.

MEMORY: Karma needs rebirth. If fruits mature beyond one life, there must be a further life for them to mature IN -- otherwise justice is impossible.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

2. REBIRTH (Karma-Saṃsāra) FACT:

- **Doctrine:** the soul, driven by **karma**, is repeatedly reborn until liberated; birth-conditions reflect past deeds. Shared by Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism, and (transformed) Buddhism. FACT:
- **Rebirth in Karma theory (2023 PYQ):** rebirth is the **mechanism by which karmic debts are discharged** - without rebirth, karma's justice (fruits maturing beyond one life) is impossible. FACT:
- **Gītā (2025 PYQ):** the imperishable soul "*casts off worn-out bodies and enters new ones*" - rebirth presupposes the deathless self.
- **The Buddhist challenge (2022, 2024 PYQ):** Buddhism denies a permanent soul (**anātman/anattā**) yet affirms rebirth - what is reborn is **not a self but a causal continuum** of momentary states (a flame passing from candle to candle; *pratītyasamutpāda*). -> **rebirth WITHOUT an immortal soul**. FACT:
- **"Is immortality a necessary condition for rebirth?" (2022, 2024, 2025): ANALYSIS:**
- *Substantialist systems (Vedānta/Nyāya/Jain): YES* - a persisting soul is what transmigrates.
- *Buddhism: NO* - continuity of a causal stream suffices; no unchanging soul needed. -> the decisive counter-example.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Three karmas: sancita (stored), prarabdha (ripening now), agami (future).
- Rebirth = mechanism that lets karma's justice outrun one life.
- Buddhism: rebirth WITHOUT a soul -> continuity, not substance.
- Not fatalism: purusakara within daiva.

WRONG: Saying Buddhism denies continuity. It denies a permanent substance-self, not the causal stream.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 9-12 in Part II.

Buddhist Rebirth Without a Soul: Anatman and Causal Continuity

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Buddhism is the great counter-example: it keeps rebirth but drops the immortal soul. Picture a stream, not a traveller.

```

REBIRTH WITHOUT A SOUL -- a causal STREAM, not a traveller
candle A ==> candle B ==> candle C (flame passes on)
|           |           |
momentary   conditions  conditions
aggregates  the next     the next
|           |           |
craving + karmic formations condition future consciousness
-----
milk --> curd --> butter : neither the SAME nor ANOTHER
Q: who reaps the fruit?
A: the later stream, causally descended --
   neither the SAME nor WHOLLY OTHER
anatman is NOT nihilism: persons and consequences are real;
only a PERMANENT owner is denied
  
```

Plain version: no single passenger travels from life to life. Instead, each moment lights the next, the way one candle lights another. The later flame is continuous with the earlier one without being the very same flame.

MEMORY: flame-to-flame and milk-to-curd = continuity, not identity. Use as a MODEL, never as a proof.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.3 Buddhist rebirth without an immortal soul

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Rebirth is causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates, not transmigration of a numerically identical substance.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) All conditioned factors are impermanent; (2) no aggregate is self; (3) craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; (4) continuity therefore occurs without an unchanging owner.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Moral responsibility needs causal connectedness, not substance identity.
- **Distinction.** FACT: *Anātman* is not nihilism: Buddhism denies an independent permanent self, not conventional persons or causal consequences.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Flame-to-flame and milk-to-curd illustrate neither strict identity nor total difference.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: If no same agent persists, who receives karmic fruit? The reply is that the later stream is causally descended-neither the same nor wholly other.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- anatman + pratityasamutpada = rebirth as causal stream.
- Models: flame-to-flame, milk-to-curd (continuity, not identity).
- "Neither the same nor wholly other" answers the who-reaps-fruit objection.
- anatman is not nihilism; 2018 = significance of the anti-theistic stand.

WRONG: Using the flame analogy as a proof. It illustrates a model of continuity.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 13-16 in Part II.

Liberation Across Schools: the Parity Bench

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

"Liberation" is a shared word covering incompatible destinations. Lay them on one bench and the differences pop out.

Term	School	What ENDS	What REMAINS	Conscious in it?
moksa	Advaita	avidya (ignorance)	Brahman alone	yes -- non-dual bliss
moksa	Visistadvaita	karmic bondage	jiva WITH God	yes -- in communion
apavarga	Nyaya-Vaisesika	pain + its causes	the self-substance	NO consciousness
kaivalya	Samkhya-Yoga	aviveka	purusa, isolated	pure, contentless
kevala	Jainism	karmic matter	perfected jiva	yes -- omniscient
nirvana	Buddhism	craving, dukkha	no self stated	-- (misleading)
resurrection	Semitic	death	embodied person	yes -- before God

Plain version: some traditions think freedom is bliss, some think it is the mere switching-off of pain, one thinks it is lonely pure awareness, one thinks it is omniscient perfection, and one refuses to say a self remains at all.

MEMORY: Consciousness ladder -- Nyaya NONE, Buddhism no-self, Samkhya contentless, Advaita/Visistadvaita/Jain positive. Fix this and you cannot merge.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

3. LIBERATION FACT: (the goal - varies by school)

School	Term	Nature of liberation	Soul in mokṣa
Advaita	mokṣa (jīvanmukti/videhamukti)	ātman realises identity with Brahman; ignorance (avidyā) ends	pure Brahman-consciousness (bliss)
Viśiṣṭādvaita	mokṣa	jīva reaches God, serves in bliss (never becomes God)	individual soul persists in communion
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	apavarga (2024)	absolute cessation of pain; soul freed of all qualities incl. consciousness	soul exists, but without consciousness/bliss
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	kaivalya	puruṣa isolated from prakṛti	pure isolated consciousness
Jainism	kaivalya/mokṣa	jīva sheds all karmic matter -> infinite knowledge/bliss, rises to top of universe	perfected, omniscient soul
Buddhism	nirvāṇa	extinction of craving/dukkha; blowing-out	no self - cessation of the causal stream
Plato/Western	-	soul returns to the realm of Forms/the divine	immortal soul contemplating truth

- **Jīvanmukti (2025 PYQ - Advaita): liberation WHILE living** - the knower of Brahman is free *now*; the body continues by *prārabdha* karma (momentum of a spun wheel) until it drops (videhamukti). FACT:
- **"Is immortality/rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024):** liberation *presupposes* bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something that is liberated (the soul) - so substantial systems say yes; **Buddhism shows liberation (nirvāṇa) is coherent even without an eternal soul.** ANALYSIS:

5A. LIBERATION PARITY BENCH - the six terms must never be merged ANALYSIS:

Term	School	Literal sense	What ends	What remains	Consciousness in the state
Mokṣa	Advaita	Release	Avidyā	Brahman alone	FACT: Self-luminous, non-dual
Mokṣa	Viśiṣṭādvaita	Release	Karmic bondage	Eternal jīva with God	FACT: Personal, in communion
Apavarga	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	Cessation	Pain and its conditions	The self-substance	WRONG: No consciousness or bliss
Kaivalya	Sāṃkhya-Yoga	Aloneness	Aviveka	Puruṣa, isolated	FACT: Pure, contentless
Kevala/Siddhātva	Jainism	Alone/perfected	Karmic matter	Perfected omniscient jīva	FACT: <i>Ananta-catuṣṭaya</i>
Nirvāṇa	Buddhism	Blowing out	Craving, <i>dukkha</i>	CAUTION: Not stated as a self	ANALYSIS: "Object" language misleads
Resurrection	Semitic	Raising	Death	The embodied person	FACT: Embodied, before God

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Seven rows, seven destinations. Never merge them.
- jīvanmukti vs videhamukti; apavarga = cessation (no consciousness).
- kevala (Jain) = omniscience; kaivalya (Samkhya) = contentless isolation.
- mokṣa "not acquired but acknowledged" (Advaita, per Griffiths).

WRONG: "All Indian liberation = merger with God." False for Nyaya, Samkhya and Buddhism.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 17-20 in Part II.

Vedantic Atman, Rebirth and Moksa: Advaita versus Visistadvaita

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Both Vedantas keep an eternal self and rebirth, but they disagree on what bondage is and what liberation delivers.

Question	Advaita (Sankara)	Visistadvaita (Ramanuja)
The self	atman = Brahman, non-dual	jiva is a real mode of God
Cause of bondage	avidya (ignorance)	karma + dependence
Chief means	jnana (knowledge)	bhakti + prapatti, by grace
What liberation is	identity realised	communion/service with God
Does the jiva persist?	individuality sublated	jiva persists eternally

Plain version: for Advaita, you were never really separate -- waking up ends the illusion of separateness. For Visistadvaita, you are genuinely distinct and liberation is loving union with God, never becoming God.

MEMORY: Advaita = IDENTITY (drop the false individuality). Visistadvaita = COMMUNION (keep the individual, reach God).

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.2 Vedāntic ātman, rebirth and mokṣa

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: The enduring self bears karmic continuity through embodiments until liberating knowledge or God-centred realisation ends bondage.
- **Argument.** FACT: Ordinary identity across changing states points to a witness; karmic responsibility requires continuity; *śruti* discloses the self's deeper nature. Advaita locates bondage in ignorance; Viśiṣṭādvaita in dependence and karma overcome through knowledge, devotion and grace.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Personal continuity requires more than causal succession, and scriptural testimony is valid in supersensible matters.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Advaita mokṣa is not the annihilation of an individual entity but sublation of mistaken individuality; Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves the jīva eternally.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: The *Gītā* compares embodiment to changing garments; use as canonical illustration, not independent demonstration.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: No memory of prior lives weakens identity. Replies distinguish memory from continuity and invoke latent dispositions, though empirical warrant remains contested.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Advaita: avidya -> jnana -> identity; individuality sublated.
- Visistadvaita: karma/dependence -> bhakti + grace -> communion; jiva persists.
- Agent paradox is Advaita's to solve (conventional agency until insight).
- moksa "not acquired but acknowledged" (Griffiths on Sankara).

WRONG: Saying Advaita liberation ANNIHILATES the self. It sublates a mistaken individuality; the Self (Brahman) is all that ever was.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 21-24 in Part II.

Jain Jiva and Bondage: the Karmic-Matter Ladder

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Jainism is unusually concrete: karma is a fine MATTER that sticks to the soul, and liberation is literally cleaning it off. Climb the ladder from bondage to release.

JAIN LADDER -- how the soul is bound and then freed
TOP OF UNIVERSE * liberated jiva: ananta-catustaya
^ (infinite knowledge, perception,

		bliss, energy)
NIRJARA	austerity	SHEDS stored karmic matter
SAMVARA	restraint	STOPS fresh influx
BANDHA	karmic matter	BINDS to the jiva
ASRAVA	passions/action	ATTRACT karmic matter
START	jiva + karma;	dust clings to an oily body

Plain version: every living thing is an eternal conscious soul, currently dusty with karmic matter kicked up by its own passions. Stop stirring the dust (samvara), then wipe off what has settled (nirjara), and the soul shines with its native infinite qualities.

MEMORY: A-B-S-N: Asrava (influx) -> Bandha (bondage) -> Samvara (stoppage) -> Nirjara (shedding) -> kevala/siddhatva.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.4 Jain jīva and liberation

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Every living being is an eternal conscious *jīva* obscured and weighed down by karmic matter; liberation is complete stoppage and shedding of that matter.
- **Argument.** FACT: Passions and action attract karmic particles (*āsrava*); bondage (*bandha*) binds them to the soul; restraint stops influx (*saṃvara*); austerity sheds accumulated karma (*nirjarā*); liberated *jīva* manifests infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Consciousness belongs intrinsically to an enduring substance and karma is quasi-material.
- **Distinction.** FACT: Jain liberation perfects individuality; it is neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without self.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: Dust adhering to an oily body illustrates karmic matter attaching through passions.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: Interaction between non-material consciousness and karmic matter is obscure. Jainism treats extension and embodiment as modes of *jīva* during bondage.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- *jīva* = eternal conscious soul, obscured by karmic MATTER.
- Ladder: asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> kevala/siddhatva.
- Liberation = perfected individuality + ananta-catustaya.
- Jain kevala = omniscience (NOT Samkhya's contentless kaivalya).

WRONG: Answering only "the soul is eternal" and skipping the bondage machinery. 2022 asks for BOTH.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 25-28 in Part II.

Cessation and Isolation: Nyaya Apavarga, Advaita Jivanmukti and Samkhya-Yoga Kaivalya

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Three liberations that are easy to confuse because none of them is "bliss-union". Line them up.

Axis	Nyaya apavarga	Advaita jivanmukti	Samkhya-Yoga kaivalya
What it is	cessation of pain	identity realised now	isolation of purusa
Consciousness	NONE remains	Brahman-bliss	pure, contentless
Embodied now?	at death only	yes, then videhamukti	yes (SK 67), then videha
Residue image	--	prarabdha (spun wheel)	gunas' momentum (wheel)
Key texts	Nyaya chain	prarabdha	SK 62-63, 67-68; YS 1.24

Plain version: Nyaya says freedom is switching off pain (and, with it, consciousness). Advaita says freedom is waking up now, while the body coasts to a stop. Samkhya says freedom is realising that pure consciousness was never entangled in nature at all.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.5 Nyāya apavarga and Advaita jīvanmukti

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: Nyāya liberation is final cessation of pain and pain-generating qualities; Advaita *jīvanmukti* is freedom through knowledge while bodily life continues.
- **Argument.** FACT: Nyāya traces suffering through defect, activity, rebirth and false knowledge; true knowledge reverses the chain. Advaita knowledge destroys ignorance immediately, while *prārabdha* karma accounts for the residual body.
- **Presupposition.** ANALYSIS: Nyāya treats consciousness as adventitious to self; Advaita treats consciousness as self's essence and karma as unable to survive liberating knowledge except in already-fructifying form.
- **Distinction.** FACT: *Jīvanmukti* differs from *videhamukti*; apavarga differs from positive heavenly pleasure.
- **Canonical example.** FACT: The potter's wheel continues briefly after the push ceases: bodily momentum after ignorance is destroyed.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: If knowledge destroys karma, why does embodiment remain? Advaita distinguishes accumulated and future karma from already-fructifying *prārabdha*.

8.9 Sāṃkhya and Yoga: kaivalya, and how it differs from every other liberation > Cross-link: Paper I - Sāṃkhya and Paper I - Yoga. This module carries only what the religion clause needs; the tattva-derivation belongs to Paper I.

- **Doctrine statement (Sāṃkhya).** FACT: Reality is exhausted by **two** kinds of principle: *puruṣa* - plural, inactive, attributeless **pure consciousness**, mere witness (*sākṣin*), by nature already isolated (*kevala*) - and *prakṛti* - one, unconscious, active, constituted by the three *guṇas*. Bondage is **not** a real bond but **aviveka**: *the failure to discriminate puruṣa from buddhi**, so that *prakṛti*'s states are misattributed to consciousness.
- **Argument.** FACT: (1) The *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* opens from the fact of the **threefold suffering** (*ādhyātmika* - bodily/mental; *ādhibhautika* - from other beings; *ādhidaivika* - from natural/cosmic forces) and the failure of ordinary and ritual means to end it permanently. (2) Effects pre-exist in their cause (*satkāryavāda*), so evolution is transformation of *prakṛti*, not creation. (3) Consciousness cannot be a product of the unconscious, hence *puruṣa* is distinct. (4) Liberation is **viveka-khyāti** - *discriminative discernment* - *after which prakṛti ceases to display herself to that puruṣa*. (5) The result is **kaivalya**: aloneness, the standing of consciousness in its own nature.
- FACT: **The doctrine that wins marks:** *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* 62-63 states that, strictly, **no puruṣa is bound, released or transmigrating**; it is *prakṛti*, in her manifold forms, who binds herself, transmigrates and releases herself. Liberation is therefore the correction of a **misattribution**, not an event in consciousness.
- FACT: **Jīvanmukti in Sāṃkhya:** SK 67 uses the **potter's wheel that continues to spin after the potter's hand is withdrawn** - the body persists on residual momentum after discriminative knowledge; SK 68 gives *videha-kaivalya* at the fall of the body. ANALYSIS: Note the parallel with Advaita's *prārabdha* image and the difference in metaphysics: for Advaita the residue is karmic, for Sāṃkhya it is the *guṇas*' momentum.
- **Doctrine statement (Yoga).** FACT: Pātañjala Yoga accepts Sāṃkhya's metaphysics and adds a **practical psychology and an Īśvara**. *Yoga-sūtra* 1.2: yoga is the **restriction of the modifications of the mind** (*citta-vṛtti-nirodha*); 1.3: then the seer abides in its own nature. The five *kleśas* (2.3) are *avidyā*, *asmitā*, *rāga*, *dveṣa*, *abhiniveśa*, with *avidyā* as the field of the rest. The eightfold path (*aṣṭāṅga*: *yama*, *niyama*, *āsana*, *prāṇāyāma*, *pratyāhāra*, *dhāraṇā*, *dhyāna*, *samādhi*) moves from *saṃprajñāta* to *asaṃprajñāta samādhi*, through *dharma-megha-samādhi* (4.29) to *kaivalya*. FACT: YS 4.34 defines **kaivalya** as the counter-flow (*pratiprasava*) of the *guṇas* now empty of purpose for *puruṣa* - or, equivalently, the power of consciousness (*citi-śakti*) established in its own nature.
- FACT: **Yoga's Īśvara is not a creator.** YS 1.24 defines Īśvara as a **special puruṣa** untouched by *kleśa*, *karma*, *vipāka* and *āśaya*; he is the teacher of the ancient teachers and the object of *Īśvara-praṇidhāna*, which is **one optional means among others**, not the ground of the world. This makes Yoga the decisive Indian case of **theism without creation** - route to Religion without God.
- **Distinction (the whole point of this module).** FACT: *Kaivalya* is **isolation**, and it is not: Advaita's *mokṣa* (realised **identity** with Brahman), Viśiṣṭādvaita's *mokṣa* (**communion** with God), Nyāya's *apavarga* (cessation of

pain **and of consciousness**), Jain *kaivalya/siddhatva* (**perfected omniscient individuality**), or Buddhist *nirvāṇa* (**cessation of craving**, no self). ANALYSIS: Note the terminological trap: Jainism *also* uses *kevala/kaivalya* - but there it means **omniscience (kevala-jñāna)**, the opposite of Sāṃkhya's contentless isolation.

- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: (a) **Plurality of puruṣas**: if each puruṣa is attributeless and inactive, nothing distinguishes them, so Sāṃkhya's pluralism collapses into Advaita's one. *Reply*: difference is established by the observed difference of birth, death and experience - a reply Advaitins find question-begging. (b) **Why does prakṛti act at all?** *Reply*: she acts "for the sake of puruṣa", illustrated by the milk that flows unconsciously for the calf - but a purpose in the unconscious is exactly what Nyāya objects to. (c) **Is a contentless liberation desirable?** *Reply*: Sāṃkhya explicitly denies that kaivalya is bliss; it is the *ending* of the threefold suffering, and offering more would be dishonest.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Sāṃkhya-Yoga gives the sharpest Indian statement that liberation is **epistemic correction, not ontological change** - nothing is added, nothing is destroyed, and consciousness was free all along. Its cost is a liberation with no positive content and a dualism whose two terms cannot explain their own association."

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- apavarga = cessation of pain AND consciousness (no bliss).
- jivanmukti = knowledge frees now; prarabdha coasts the body (spun wheel).
- kaivalya = isolation of puruṣa; SK 62-63 = prakṛti binds/releases, not puruṣa.
- YS 1.24 = Isvara is a special puruṣa, NOT a creator.

WRONG: Saying Samkhya's puruṣa is bound and then released. SK 62-63 says the opposite -- the misattribution IS the doctrine.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 29-32 in Part II.

Paths to Liberation: Bhakti, and the Jnana-Karma-Bhakti Question

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Two owner-questions live here: is bhakti a real path, and how do knowledge, action and devotion relate? Use the matrix.

Path	What it does	Direct means?	Champion
jnana (knowledge)	REMOVES ignorance	yes, for Sankara	Advaita
karma (action)	QUALIFIES / purifies	no (Advaita); yes (Mimamsa)	Mimamsa
bhakti (devotion)	RECEIVES grace	yes, for theistic Vedanta	Ramanuja, etc.

Plain version: think of a locked room. Knowledge says the lock was never really locked -- just SEE it (removal). Action says polish the key and earn entry (production). Devotion says ask the owner to open it (grace/reception).

MEMORY: Karma QUALIFIES, bhakti RECEIVES, jnana REMOVES -- three means of different kinds, not three equal options.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.6 Bhakti as a path to liberation (2018 Q7(c) owner-module)

- **Doctrine statement.** FACT: *Bhakti* is loving devotion to a personal God held, in the theistic Vedāntas and the Bhakti traditions, to be a **direct means (sādhana) of liberation** - and, crucially, one available irrespective of caste, gender, language or scholastic training.
- **Textual base (cite precisely).** FACT: *Bhagavad Gītā* chs. 7-12 and the concluding *carama-śloka* **18.66** (*sarva-dharmāṇaṃ parityajya mām ekaṃ śaraṇaṃ vraja* - abandon all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone); **9.22** on the Lord securing what the exclusively devoted lack; **9.32** on the accessibility of the path. FACT: *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* **7.5.23** lists the **nine limbs (navadhā bhakti)**: *śravaṇa* (hearing), *kīrtana* (praising), *smaraṇa* (remembering), *pāda-sevana* (service at the feet), *arcana* (ritual worship), *vandana* (salutation), *dāśya* (servitude), *sakhya*

(friendship), *ātma-nivedana* (self-offering). FACT: *Nārada Bhakti Sūtra* defines bhakti as of the nature of supreme love for the Lord; *Śaṅḍīya Bhakti Sūtra* as supreme attachment to Īśvara.

- **Typology (marks lie in the distinctions).** FACT: *Parā* (higher, disinterested) vs *aparā/gauṇī* (preliminary, ritual-supported); *vaidhī* (governed by scriptural injunction) vs *rāgānugā* (spontaneous, following the passion of exemplary devotees - Gauḍīya); **saguṇa bhakti** (Tulsīdās, Sūrdās, Mīrābāī - devotion to a form) vs **nirguṇa bhakti** (Kabīr, Nānak, Dādū - devotion to a formless ultimate, which shows bhakti does **not** logically require an iconic God); the five *bhāvas* of Gauḍīya rasa-theory (*śānta, dāsyā, sakhyā, vātsalya, mādhyūya*).
- **The systematic Vedāntic positions.** FACT: - **Rāmānuja:** bhakti is *dhruvānusmṛti* - steady, uninterrupted loving meditation; because it presupposes qualifications not everyone has, he admits **prapatti/śaraṇāgati** (unconditional self-surrender) as an equally efficacious and universally accessible means. Liberation is finally by **divine grace**. - FACT: The famous *Śrīvaiṣṇava* split over how grace and effort combine: **mārjāra-nyāya** (the cat carries the kitten - grace alone, Teṅkalai) vs **markaṭa-nyāya** (the young monkey must cling - grace plus effort, Vaḍakalai). This is the single most efficient way to show you understand the grace/effort problem. - **Madhva:** bhakti is *jñāna-pūrvaka-sneha* - affection preceded by knowledge of the Lord's supremacy; it is both the means and, in graded form, the content of liberation; *prasāda* (grace) is decisive and *taratamya** fixes the degree.
- **Vallabha:** *puṣṭi-mārga*, the path of nourishing grace, with grace unearned by works.
- **Caitanya (Gauḍīya):** *prema-bhakti* is not merely a means to mokṣa but a **fifth and higher puruṣārtha** - the devotee may even prefer service to liberation. - **Advaita (Śaṅkara):** *bhakti/upāsana* is **preparatory, not directly liberating** - it produces *citta-śuddhi* (purification) and one-pointedness, qualifying one for *jñāna*, which alone removes ignorance. CAUTION: The often-quoted definition of bhakti as *svasvarūpānusandhānam* ("investigation into one's own true nature") comes from the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi**, whose ascription to Śaṅkara is disputed - attribute it to the Advaita tradition, not to Śaṅkara personally.
- **Argument that bhakti is a genuine and sufficient path.** ANALYSIS: (1) **Accessibility:** it dispenses with Sanskrit learning and ritual entitlement, which is why the movement is vernacular and socially open (*Ālvārs* and *Nāyanārs*, *Basavaṇṇa's* *Vīraśaiva*, Kabīr, Nānak, Mīrā, Tukārām). (2) **Whole-person engagement:** it enlists affect and will, not intellect alone, and so transforms conduct as well as cognition. (3) **The incapacity argument:** if bondage is beginningless, the bound *jīva* cannot lift itself; only grace can, and bhakti is the posture in which grace is received. (4) **Textual warrant:** *Gītā* 18.66 makes surrender the final teaching of the text.
- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: (a) **Love presupposes duality**, so bhakti cannot deliver Advaitic identity. Reply: Advaita agrees - and therefore classifies bhakti as means, not end; the theistic Vedāntas simply deny that identity is the goal. (b) **Emotionalism:** devotion without discernment can degenerate into sentiment or fanaticism. Reply: the traditions build in *vaidhī* discipline, scriptural regulation and the *jñāna-pūrvaka* requirement (Madhva). (c) **If grace decides, effort is otiose.** Reply: the cat/monkey dispute is precisely the tradition's own recognition of the problem; neither side eliminates the other term. (d) **Bhakti presupposes a saguṇa God** and so is unavailable to Buddhism, Jainism or *Mīmāṃsā*. Reply: nirguṇa bhakti shows the requirement is a *personal focus*, not an iconic form - but the objection stands against strictly non-theistic systems.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Bhakti is a complete path in the theistic Vedāntas and a preparatory discipline in Advaita. Its philosophical significance is not emotional but **structural**: it relocates liberation from achievement to reception, and thereby makes mokṣa a matter of grace rather than of qualification."

8.7 Jñāna, karma and bhakti - how the three means are related (2020 Q8(c) owner-module)

- **The exact question.** ANALYSIS: Are knowledge, action and devotion **alternative** routes (choose one), **sequential** stages (one leads to the next), or **combined** (all three jointly)? Every Vedāntic school answers differently, and naming the disagreement is the answer.
- **The analytic apparatus (deploy this early; it is what separates a 7 from a 12).** ANALYSIS: - **Direct means (sākṣāt-sādhana)** vs **auxiliary/remote aid (ārād-upakāra)**. - **Means vs qualification (adhikāra):** karma may qualify one for knowledge without being a means to liberation. - **Production model vs removal model** of liberation: if mokṣa is a *result to be produced*, action can produce it; if it is the *removal of an error*, only knowledge can remove it. Śaṅkara's entire case rests on the second.
- **The positions.** FACT: - **Śaṅkara (Advaita): jñāna alone liberates.** Mokṣa is not a producible effect (*sādhya*) but the eternally accomplished nature of the self (*siddha*), obscured by *avidyā*; ignorance is destroyed only by knowledge, as darkness by light. He therefore **rejects jñāna-karma-samuccaya-vāda** - the doctrine that

knowledge and ritual action jointly produce liberation. Karma and upāsana remain indispensable preparations: they generate citta-śuddhi and the sādhanā-catuṣṭaya (viveka, vairāgya, the six inner accomplishments, mumukṣutva); knowledge then matures through śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*.

- **Rāmānuja (Viśiṣṭādvaita): sequential culmination** - karma-yoga purifies, jñāna-yoga discloses the self's nature as a mode of God, and both flow into bhakti-yoga, which is the direct means; prapatti is the accessible alternative. Rāmānuja therefore accepts a form of samuccaya that Śaṅkara denies.
- **Madhva (Dvaita):** knowledge of the Lord's supremacy is prior; bhakti ripened from it is the means; prasāda is decisive.
- **Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā: karma alone** - the Veda is essentially injunctive, and knowledge-passages are subordinate to ritual action. This is the pūrvapakṣa Śaṅkara is arguing against, and naming it shows you know why the dispute exists.
- **FACT: The Gītā's own signal:** 5.4-5 states that only the immature (bālāḥ) declare Sāṃkhya (knowledge) and Yoga (action) to be different; one who reaches by one reaches by the other. The Gītā thus supports **convergence**, which is why three great commentators could each claim it - **Śaṅkara for jñāna, Rāmānuja for bhakti, and Tilak (Gītā-Rahasya) for karma**. - **FACT: Vivekananda: the four yogas** (jñāna, bhakti, karma, rāja*) are **temperament-matched** routes to the same realisation - a psychological, not a metaphysical, pluralism.
- **Presupposition. ANALYSIS:** That liberation has a single determinate nature, so that the means-question has one right answer; the moment liberation itself is plural (Advaitic identity vs Vaiṣṇava communion), the means necessarily diverge.
- **Objection -> reply. ANALYSIS: Objection:** the "convergence" reading is diplomatic mush - knowledge that dissolves individuality and devotion that preserves it cannot terminate in the same state. **Reply:** they converge in function (removal of egoic self-appropriation) while diverging in terminus; the honest answer says exactly this rather than harmonising. **ANALYSIS: Second objection:** if karma cannot liberate, why does the Gītā command action? **Reply:** niṣkāma-karma - action without appropriation of the fruit - is not liberating by producing mokṣa but by dismantling the agency-sense that sustains bondage.
- **Verdict formula. ANALYSIS:** "In the Indian tradition all three are means, but not means of the same kind. Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jñāna removes. Whether they combine or exclude one another is settled not by piety but by one's answer to a prior question - is liberation produced or uncovered?"

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jñāna removes.
- Production vs removal model decides which is the DIRECT means.
- Śaṅkara rejects jñāna-karma-samuccaya; Rāmānuja accepts a graded one.
- marjara (grace alone) vs markata (grace + effort) = the grace-effort problem.
- Vivekacudamani ascription DISPUTED -> "Advaita tradition", not "Śaṅkara".

WRONG: "All three are equal." Name the disagreement instead.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 33-36 in Part II.

Resurrection vs Rebirth vs Reincarnation; Inter-School Debates, Criticisms and Traps

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

The last cuts: resurrection is not rebirth, rebirth is wider than reincarnation, and every objection has a ready reply.

ANSWER SPINE -- turn any objection into marks
 OBJECTION REPLY (one line each)
 memory gap -> memory != continuity; latent saṃskaras
 duplication -> substance = one bearer; Buddhism drops numerical identity
 moral desert -> karma explains, does not license blame
 who seeks mokṣa? -> conventional agency until insight ends error
 replica = a copy? -> Hick: a UNIQUE replica meets our criteria
 re-assembly of body -> Aquinas (soul=form) / van Inwagen (God keeps a core)
 resurrection=rebirth-> NO: one life, divine act, final judgement

Plain version: resurrection is God raising the whole embodied person ONCE at the end of history; rebirth is a beginningless karmic re-embodiment you exit by liberation. Reincarnation is the narrower word that assumes a substantial soul re- entering flesh -- right for Vedanta/Nyaya/Jainism, wrong for Buddhism.

MEMORY: Resurrection = ONE life, divine act, judgement. Rebirth = MANY lives, karma, exit. Reincarnation = rebirth that assumes a SUBSTANCE.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8.8 Resurrection versus rebirth - and rebirth versus reincarnation

- **Doctrine statement. FACT: Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series. They are not variants of one idea: they differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos and identity-bearer.
- **Two Western strands that are often wrongly merged. FACT: Immortality of the soul** is Greek/Platonic: the soul is naturally deathless and death releases it from the body. **Resurrection of the dead** is Hebrew-Christian-Islamic: the person is a **psychosomatic unity**, so survival requires God to restore the whole person; death is real and defeat is reversed only by divine act. **Oscar Cullmann** (*Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?*, 1955) argues the two are theologically **opposed**, not complementary - a high-value citation.
- **Comparative grid.**

Axis	Resurrection	Rebirth (Indian)
Number of lives	FACT: One earthly life	FACT: Beginningless series
Mechanism	Divine act at the end of history	<i>Karma</i> maturing through <i>saṃsāra</i>
Judge	God, in a final judgement	The karmic law itself; in Nyāya/Rāmānuja God <i>ratifies</i> rather than decrees
Telos	Restored embodied life in communion with God	Exit from the series - mokṣa, nirvāṇa, kaivalya, apavarga
Identity-bearer	The person re-constituted by God (soul as form, or replica)	The ātman/jīva - or, in Buddhism, a causal stream
Body	Essential; a "spiritual body" is still a body	Discarded like clothing (Gītā 2.22); the subtle body (<i>sūkṣma-śarīra</i>) carries dispositions
Direction of time	Linear, eschatological	Cyclical, with a linear exit
Moral function	Accountability before a personal God	Self-regulating desert without an external prosecutor

- **The identity problem, both ways. ANALYSIS: For resurrection:** the **gap problem** (what exists between death and resurrection?) and the **re-assembly problem** (the classical "cannibal" objection - if matter is shared between bodies, whose atoms are raised?). Three standard replies: **Aquinas** - the rational soul is the *form* of the body and secures continuity; **Peter van Inwagen** - God preserves the body (or a core of it) and leaves a simulacrum; **John Hick's replica theory** - an exact psychophysical replica, with continuity of memory and character, appearing in a different space, is *the same person* for all purposes that matter. **For rebirth:** the **memory objection** - no recollection of prior lives; the reply distinguishes psychological memory from metaphysical continuity and appeals to latent *saṃskāras/vāsanās*.
- **ANALYSIS: Rebirth vs reincarnation (2019 Q8(a) demands this).** In careful usage, **reincarnation** (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes a **substantial soul** that re-enters a new body - apt for Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism. **Rebirth** is the wider, more neutral term, and is the only correct term for **Buddhism**, which affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) without any transmigrating substance. Sanskrit registers the same range: *punarjanma* (rebirth), *punarāvṛtti* (return), *saṃsāra* (the wandering itself). **FACT:** The Gītā's *pitṛyāna* teaching (9.21 - those who exhaust their merit "return to the world of mortals") shows that even heaven is a *within-saṃsāra* stage, not resurrection.

- **Objection -> reply.** ANALYSIS: **Objection to resurrection:** a replica is a duplicate, not a survivor - and if God could make one replica, he could make two, which destroys identity. **Reply:** Hick restricts the case to a *unique* replica and argues that in the absence of a rival claimant our ordinary criteria are satisfied; critics answer that possibility of duplication already shows the criterion is not identity. ANALYSIS: **Objection to rebirth:** it is empirically untestable and morally hazardous. **Reply:** untestability is shared with resurrection, and explanatory karma does not license social judgement of the sufferer.
- **Verdict formula.** ANALYSIS: "Resurrection and rebirth answer *different* questions. Resurrection asks how a person can survive when the person is essentially embodied; rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when a single life is too short. Neither is a version of the other, and the identity problem - how the later being is the *same* - is unresolved on both sides, though for opposite reasons."

9. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

School	Bearer of continuity	Rebirth	Liberation	Personal identity after liberation
Plato	FACT: Simple/rational soul	ANALYSIS: Includes transmigration themes	Purification/contemplation	Persists
Advaita	FACT: Empirical subtle-body continuity; ultimately ātman	Yes	Knowledge of Brahman	Separate individuality sublated
Viśiṣṭādvaita	FACT: Enduring jīva	Yes	Communion/service to God	Persists
Nyāya	FACT: Eternal self-substance	Yes	Cessation of pain/qualities	Persists
Jainism	FACT: Eternal jīva	Yes	Karmic matter removed	Perfected individuality
Buddhism	FACT: Causal stream, no substance	Yes	Cessation of craving/dukkha	No permanent self
Sāṃkhya-Yoga	FACT: Puruṣa (witness); prakṛti carries the <i>liṅga-śarīra</i>	Yes - but strictly <i>prakṛti</i> transmigrates (SK 62-63)	<i>Kaivalya</i> = isolation of consciousness	Puruṣa persists, contentless, plural
Semitic resurrection	FACT: The psychosomatic person, re-constituted by God	WRONG: No - one life	Resurrection and judgement	Persists, embodied

10. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

1. **Memory objection.** ANALYSIS: Lack of past-life memory challenges identity. **Reply:** memory is neither necessary nor sufficient for metaphysical continuity; unconscious dispositions may connect lives.
2. **Duplication objection.** ANALYSIS: If psychological continuity branches, identity becomes indeterminate. **Reply:** substance theories invoke one bearer; Buddhist theory accepts continuity without numerical identity.
3. **Moral-desert objection.** ANALYSIS: Rebirth can assign suffering to unverifiable past fault. **Reply:** karmic explanation need not legitimise social punishment; compassion remains obligatory.
4. **Liberation paradox.** ANALYSIS: Who seeks liberation if Advaita denies individuality or Buddhism denies self? **Reply:** conventional agency operates until insight removes the misconception sustaining bondage.

11. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Do not equate immortality, resurrection and rebirth.
2. ANALYSIS: Do not say Buddhism denies continuity; it denies permanent substance-self.
3. ANALYSIS: Do not describe Nyāya apavarga as positive bliss without qualification.
4. ANALYSIS: Do not make all Indian liberation doctrines merger with God.
5. ANALYSIS: Do not use the flame analogy as proof; it illustrates a causal-continuity model.
6. ANALYSIS: In jīvanmukti, distinguish knowledge destroying ignorance from *prārabdha* sustaining embodiment.
7. ANALYSIS: Do not treat **bhakti** as mere emotion. Its philosophical content is the shift from *achievement* to *reception* (grace), and the *mārjāra/markaṭa* dispute is the tradition's own statement of the grace-effort problem.

8. ANALYSIS: Do not say "Advaita rejects bhakti". Advaita makes it **preparatory** (*citta-śuddhi, upāsana*), not directly liberating - a difference of role, not of value. 9. ANALYSIS: Do not answer the jñāna/karma/bhakti question with "all three are equal". Name the disagreement: Śaṅkara rejects *jñāna-karma-samuccaya*; Rāmānuja accepts a graded *samuccaya* culminating in bhakti; Mīmāṃsā holds karma alone.
10. ANALYSIS: Do not conflate **rebirth** with **reincarnation**. Reincarnation presupposes a substantial soul re-entering flesh; rebirth is the wider term and the only correct one for Buddhism (*punarbhava*).
11. ANALYSIS: Do not present **resurrection** as rebirth in heaven. It is one life, a bodily re-constitution by divine act, and a final judgement - the opposite structure to *samsāra*. 12. ANALYSIS: Do not treat *kaivalya* as a synonym for mokṣa. In Sāṃkhya-Yoga it is **isolation of contentless consciousness**; in Jainism the cognate *kevala* means **omniscience**. The same syllable, opposite content.
13. ANALYSIS: Do not call Yoga's Īśvara a creator. YS 1.24 makes him a *special puruṣa* untouched by karma - an object of *praṇidhāna*, not a cause of the world. 14. ANALYSIS: Do not say Sāṃkhya's puruṣa is bound and released. SK 62-63 says the opposite; the misattribution is the whole doctrine.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

- Resurrection: one life, psychosomatic person, God restores, judgement, Cullmann's opposition.
- Rebirth (wider) vs reincarnation (assumes a substance; wrong for Buddhism).
- Identity replies: Aquinas (soul=form), van Inwagen (core preserved), Hick (unique replica); rebirth -> memory != continuity.
- Fourteen canonical traps sit in the CORE slice -- the answer spine retrieves them.

WRONG: Presenting resurrection as "rebirth in heaven". It is the opposite structure to samsara.

-> Drill this subtopic with MCQs 37-40, then the remedial set, in Part II.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct-option sequence rotates strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty-eight diagnostics.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

MCQ 1

On the six survival-terms, which statement is correct?

A. Rebirth is a wider term than reincarnation. B. Resurrection is a form of transmigration. C. Liberation is simply a synonym for heaven. D. Immortality and survival make exactly the same claim.

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Rebirth (esp. Buddhist punarbhava) is the wider term; reincarnation assumes a substance re-enfleshed, resurrection is one life, and liberation is exit from the cycle, not heaven.

MCQ 2

'Immortality of a substantial soul is ____ for rebirth.' The best completion is:

A. necessary and sufficient B. sufficient but not necessary C. necessary but not sufficient D. neither necessary nor sufficient

Correct answer: B

Explanation: A persisting soul would guarantee rebirth (sufficient), but Buddhism shows a soul is not required (not necessary).

MCQ 3

The decisive counter-example to 'rebirth requires an immortal soul' is:

A. Advaita Vedanta B. Nyaya-Vaisesika C. Buddhism D. Jainism

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Buddhism affirms rebirth (punarbhava) while denying a permanent self (anatman).

MCQ 4

Calling 'liberation' a family-resemblance term means:

A. all schools mean the same state by it B. it always denotes union with God C. it is meaningless across schools D. it covers several non-identical destinations that share one label

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Identity, communion, cessation, isolation and perfected individuality share the label 'liberation' without sharing one content.

MCQ 5

Plato's recollection (anamnesis) argument most directly establishes:

A. the soul's pre-existence B. bodily resurrection C. the soul's post-mortem survival on its own D. the mortality of the body

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Recollection infers that the soul knew the Forms before birth -- pre-existence, which is not yet post-mortem survival.

MCQ 6

Which is Plato's culminating ('final') argument in the Phaedo?

A. the affinity argument B. the argument from the Form of Life C. the argument from opposites D. the recollection argument

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The final argument holds that the soul essentially brings Life and so cannot admit its opposite, death.

MCQ 7

Simmias objects to Plato that the soul is:

A. a simple substance B. immortal by affinity to the Forms C. a harmony/attunement of the body D. identical with the Forms

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The harmony objection makes the soul depend on the body; Plato replies the soul rules the body and pre-exists it.

MCQ 8

Kant's paralogism, applied to immortality, shows that:

A. the soul is a knowable substance B. the soul is material C. recollection proves survival D. the soul's permanence cannot be demonstrated as a substance

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Kant denies that the soul is a knowable substance, so its indestructibility cannot be proved a priori.

MCQ 9

The three kinds of karma are:

A. sancita, prarabdha and agami B. asrava, bandha and nirjara C. sattva, rajas and tamas D. jnana, karma and bhakti

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Sancita (stored), prarabdha (now ripening) and agami (future) classify karmic debt.

MCQ 10

Rebirth is significant in karma theory chiefly because it:

A. proves the existence of God B. provides the field in which fruits maturing beyond one life are discharged C. guarantees memory of past lives D. abolishes moral responsibility

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Desert outruns a single life, so rebirth is the field where karmic fruits ripen.

MCQ 11

The claim that karma is NOT fatalism rests on:

A. adrsta alone B. prarabdha alone C. purusakara operating within daiva D. the subtle body

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Personal effort (purasakara) works within the given (daiva); present effort shapes future (agami) karma.

MCQ 12

Gita 9.21 (return from heaven once merit is exhausted) shows that:

A. heaven is final liberation B. resurrection occurs in heaven C. karma is unreal D. even heaven is a within-samsara stage, not liberation

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Heavenly sojourn ends in return to the mortal world, so it is inside samsara.

MCQ 13

In Buddhism, what is 'reborn' is best described as:

A. a dependently arisen causal stream B. an eternal atman C. a transmigrating substance D. a resurrected body

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Rebirth is causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates, not a soul.

MCQ 14

'Neither the same nor wholly other' answers the objection that:

A. Buddhism is nihilist B. if no self persists, who receives the karmic fruit? C. the flame analogy is a proof D. anatman denies conventional persons

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The later stream is causally descended from the earlier -- enough for moral responsibility without substance-identity.

MCQ 15

The flame-to-flame illustration is properly used as:

A. a proof of rebirth B. a proof of anatman C. a model of continuity without numerical identity D. evidence of an immortal soul

Correct answer: C

Explanation: It illustrates a continuity-model; it is never a demonstration.

MCQ 16

The philosophical significance of the anti-theistic stand on rebirth is that rebirth is shown to be:

A. impossible without God B. identical to resurrection C. dependent on an immortal soul D. separable from both a creator-God and a soul-substance

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Buddhism (and Jainism) run karma-rebirth-liberation without a judging God or a transmigrating substance.

MCQ 17

In Nyaya apavarga, consciousness in the liberated state is:

- A. absent B. infinite bliss C. non-dual awareness D. omniscient

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Consciousness is adventitious to the Nyaya self, so apavarga ends pain and consciousness alike -- a negative state.

MCQ 18

Which pair correctly matches liberation-term to school?

- A. kaivalya -- Advaita B. apavarga -- Nyaya-Vaisesika C. nirvana -- Jainism D. moksa -- Buddhism

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Apavarga is the Nyaya-Vaisesika term; kaivalya is Samkhya-Yoga, nirvana is Buddhist, and Buddhism does not use moksa in the Vedantic sense.

MCQ 19

Jivanmukti differs from videhamukti in that jivanmukti is:

- A. liberation only after death B. liberation of the body itself C. liberation attained while still embodied D. the resurrection of the person

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Jivanmukti is freedom while living; videhamukti is at the body's fall.

MCQ 20

Griffiths' formula that Advaitic moksa is 'not acquired but acknowledged' means:

- A. moksa is produced by ritual action B. moksa is a future heavenly reward C. moksa requires bodily resurrection D. liberation removes an error and the self was free all along

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Bondage is avidya/adhyasa, so knowledge only removes the superimposition.

MCQ 21

For Visistadvaita, in liberation the jiva:

- A. persists eternally in communion with God B. becomes numerically identical with Brahman C. is annihilated D. loses all consciousness

Correct answer: A

Explanation: The jiva is an eternal mode of God, freed into service/communion, never becoming God.

MCQ 22

The 'real agent' problem is a difficulty primarily for:

- A. Visistadvaita B. Advaita C. Nyaya D. Jainism

Correct answer: B

Explanation: If ultimate individuality is denied, Advaita must explain who is bound and freed; it appeals to conventional agency until insight.

MCQ 23

In Advaita, bondage is fundamentally:

- A. karmic matter clinging to the soul B. dependence on God C. avidya, a beginningless superimposition (adhyasa) D. the isolation of purusa from prakrti

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Bondage is ignorance -- the rope-snake superimposition -- removable only by knowledge.

MCQ 24

For Sankara, the direct means to liberation is:

A. karma alone B. bhakti as prapatti C. ritual injunction D. jnana, because bondage is ignorance

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Since liberation is the removal of avidya, only knowledge removes it; Sankara rejects jnana-karma-samuccaya.

MCQ 25

In Jainism, the influx of karmic matter into the soul is called:

A. asrava B. samvara C. nirjara D. bandha

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Asrava is influx; bandha is bondage, samvara is stoppage, nirjara is shedding.

MCQ 26

The stoppage of fresh karmic influx is:

A. asrava B. samvara C. nirjara D. kevala

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Samvara halts new influx; nirjara then sheds accumulated matter.

MCQ 27

Jain liberation is best described as:

A. identity with Brahman B. cessation of the causal stream C. perfected omniscient individuality D. contentless isolation of purusa

Correct answer: C

Explanation: The freed jiva manifests ananta-catustaya (infinite knowledge, perception, bliss, energy) -- individuality perfected, not dissolved.

MCQ 28

Jain kevala differs from Samkhya kaivalya because Jain kevala means:

A. contentless isolation B. cessation of consciousness C. union with a personal God D. omniscience (kevala-jnana)

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Same syllable, opposite content: Jain kevala is omniscience; Samkhya kaivalya is contentless isolation.

MCQ 29

Samkhya-karika 62-63 states that, strictly, what is bound and released is:

A. prakrti, not purusa B. purusa, not prakrti C. Isvara D. the individual buddhi acting alone

Correct answer: A

Explanation: No purusa is bound, released or transmigrating; prakrti binds and releases herself -- the misattribution is the whole doctrine.

MCQ 30

The potter's-wheel image (SK 67) illustrates:

A. the creation of the world B. the body persisting on residual momentum after discriminative knowledge C. the plurality of purusas D. Isvara as creator

Correct answer: B

Explanation: The wheel spins on after the hand withdraws -- like the body after viveka-khyati; it parallels Advaita's prarabdha image.

MCQ 31

Yoga-sutra 1.24 characterises Isvara as:

A. the material cause of the world B. the karmic judge of souls C. a special purusa untouched by karma D. identical with prakrti

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Isvara is a special purusa, object of pranidhana -- theism without creation.

MCQ 32

Samkhya-Yoga kaivalya is best described as:

A. identity with Brahman B. communion with a personal God C. omniscient perfection D. the isolation of contentless pure consciousness

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Kaivalya is aloneness -- purusa standing in its own nature, explicitly not bliss.

MCQ 33

The nine limbs of devotion (navadha bhakti) are enumerated in:

A. Bhagavata Purana 7.5.23 B. Bhagavad Gita 18.66 C. Yoga-sutra 1.24 D. Samkhya-karika 62

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Bhagavata 7.5.23 lists sravana, kirtana, smarana, pada-sevana, arcana, vandana, dasya, sakhya, atma-nivedana.

MCQ 34

Sankara rejects jnana-karma-samuccaya because he holds that liberation is:

A. produced by action B. the removal of ignorance, not a produced effect C. a graded combination of all means D. attained by ritual alone

Correct answer: B

Explanation: On the removal model, only knowledge dispels avidya; action merely purifies.

MCQ 35

The marjara-nyaya versus markata-nyaya dispute concerns:

A. the reality of the world B. the number of purusas C. the relation of grace and effort in liberation D. the correct definition of karma

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Cat-hold (grace alone) versus monkey-hold (grace plus effort) is the tradition's own statement of the grace-effort problem.

MCQ 36

The Vivekacudamani definition of bhakti should be attributed to:

A. Sankara personally B. Ramanuja C. Madhva D. the Advaita tradition, since the ascription to Sankara is disputed

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Provenance discipline: say 'the Advaita tradition', never 'Sankara wrote'.

MCQ 37

Oscar Cullmann (1955) argues that immortality of the soul and resurrection of the dead are:

A. theologically opposed, not complementary B. two names for one doctrine C. both Greek in origin D. both forms of rebirth

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Cullmann's thesis is that the Greek and Hebrew-Christian conceptions are opposed.

MCQ 38

'Reincarnation', in careful usage, differs from 'rebirth' because reincarnation:

- A. applies straightforwardly to Buddhism
- B. presupposes a substantial soul re-entering flesh
- C. denies any continuity between lives
- D. is the wider, more neutral term

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Reincarnation assumes a substance re-enfleshed; rebirth is wider and the only correct term for Buddhism.

MCQ 39

Hick's replica theory is best presented as:

- A. a proof of the soul's natural immortality
- B. a Vedantic doctrine of liberation
- C. a thought-experiment defence of resurrection identity
- D. a denial of personal identity

Correct answer: C

Explanation: An exact, unique psychophysical replica is argued to be the same person; the duplication objection is the standard reply.

MCQ 40

Which reply to the resurrection re-assembly problem is correctly paired?

- A. Hick -- the soul is the form of the body
- B. Aquinas -- an exact replica in another space
- C. Cullmann -- God substitutes a simulacrum
- D. van Inwagen -- God preserves a core of the body

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Aquinas = soul as form; Hick = replica; van Inwagen = God preserves a core or leaves a simulacrum.

Remedial MCQ 41

A common error is to say Buddhism denies continuity. Correctly, Buddhism denies:

- A. a permanent substance-self, not continuity
- B. rebirth altogether
- C. moral responsibility
- D. causation of any kind

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Anatman denies a permanent self, while the causal stream secures continuity.

Remedial MCQ 42

A frequent trap calls Nyaya apavarga 'positive bliss'. Correctly, apavarga is:

- A. union with a personal God
- B. the cessation of pain and of consciousness
- C. omniscient perfection
- D. the isolation of purusa

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Consciousness is adventitious to the Nyaya self, so apavarga is release from pain, not beatitude.

Remedial MCQ 43

Students merge kaivalya and kevala. In Samkhya kaivalya is ____; in Jainism kevala is ____:

- A. omniscience; contentless isolation
- B. bliss; cessation
- C. contentless isolation; omniscience
- D. communion; identity

Correct answer: C

Explanation: Same syllable, opposite content -- Samkhya isolation versus Jain omniscience.

Remedial MCQ 44

It is wrong to say 'Advaita rejects bhakti'. Advaita treats bhakti as:

- A. the direct means to moksha
- B. a fifth purusartha above liberation
- C. wholly irrelevant to liberation
- D. preparatory (citta-suddhi), qualifying one for jnana

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Bhakti is a difference of ROLE, not of value: it purifies and qualifies, and jnana alone removes ignorance.

Remedial MCQ 45

The best correction to 'all Indian liberation is merger with God' is that it is false for:

A. Nyaya, Samkhya and Buddhism B. Advaita and Visistadvaita C. Jainism only D. no school at all

Correct answer: A

Explanation: Nyaya apavarga, Samkhya kaivalya and Buddhist nirvana involve no merger with God.

Remedial MCQ 46

Presenting resurrection as 'rebirth in heaven' is wrong because resurrection is:

A. a beginningless karmic series B. one life, a bodily re-constitution by divine act, with final judgement C. driven by karma maturing across lives D. an exit from samsara

Correct answer: B

Explanation: Resurrection is the opposite structure to samsara: linear, eschatological, and divinely enacted.

Remedial MCQ 47

The 'convergence' reading of jnana/karma/bhakti is best defended by saying they converge in ____ and diverge in ____:

A. terminus; function B. text; author C. function; terminus D. grace; effort

Correct answer: C

Explanation: They converge in function (removing egoic self-appropriation) but diverge in terminus (identity vs communion).

Remedial MCQ 48

Calling Yoga's Isvara a 'creator' is a trap; YS 1.24 makes Isvara:

A. the material cause of the world B. the karmic judge of all souls C. numerically identical with Brahman D. a special purusa, object of pranidhana, not the ground of the world

Correct answer: D

Explanation: Yoga is the decisive Indian case of theism without creation.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ten-unit exam-application bridge

The Six Survival-Terms and the Necessity Question

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

This subtopic is the engine room for every "necessary condition" stem and the "presupposition of religion" stem.

- 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks -- immortality a necessary postulate for rebirth, w.r.t.

Buddhism -> the modal verdict lives here.

- 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks -- must we adhere to immortality and rebirth for a robust

conception of liberation -> chain all three terms.

- 2025 Q7(c), 15 marks -- immortality a necessary condition for rebirth, w.r.t.

the Bhagavad Gita -> same modal spine, Gita-specific evidence.

- 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks -- immortality a basic presupposition of religion.

MEMORY: 10-mark necessity spine -> define the disputed necessity -> give the substantialist YES -> deploy the Buddhist counter-example -> close with the exact modal claim (sufficient, not necessary).

Immortality of the Soul: Plato's Four Proofs and the Western Critique

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks -- critically examine Plato's apriori proofs -> FOUR

mini-assessments, never one summary. This subtopic is the whole answer.

- 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks -- immortality of soul w.r.t. Hindu tradition -> use Plato as the Western foil, then Vedanta/Nyaya/Jain eternal-self doctrines.
- 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks -- immortality as presupposition of religion -> Plato + the resurrection route.

MEMORY: 20-mark Plato spine -> state each of the 4 arguments -> assess each for validity AND for whether it reaches survival, not just pre-existence -> Simmias objection and reply -> Kant's paralogism -> verdict: suggestive, not probative.

Rebirth: Karma, Samsara and the Buddhist Challenge

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks -- significance of rebirth in the theory of Karma.
- 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks -- Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation (define each, then interlock; the reincarnation-vs-rebirth cut is delivered in Subtopic 10).
- 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks -- Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.
- 2022 Q5(c) / 2025 Q7(c) -- the necessity stems draw their rebirth content here.

MEMORY: 15-mark karma spine -> define karma (act + adṛṣṭa) and its three kinds -> rebirth as the field where fruits mature -> Buddhist continuity twist -> memory + desert objections and replies -> verdict on continuity vs substance.

Buddhist Rebirth Without a Soul: Anatman and Causal Continuity

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks -- immortality a necessary postulate for rebirth, w.r.t. Buddhism -> this subtopic is the core of the answer.
- 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks -- philosophical significance of anti-theistic religions' stand on rebirth -> continuity-without-substance + morality-without-God.
- 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks -- Buddhism as the case that liberation is coherent without an eternal soul.

MEMORY: 10-mark Buddhism spine -> substantialist assumption stated -> anatman + pratītyasamutpāda -> flame/milk models -> "who reaps the fruit?" reply -> verdict: immortality sufficient, not necessary; Buddhism is decisive.

Liberation Across Schools: the Parity Bench

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks -- apavarga in Nyaya-Vaisesika (cessation, no bliss).
- 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks -- jīvanmukti in Advaita (embodied liberation).
- 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks -- Advaita liberation + the role of knowledge.
- 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks -- liberation without a real agent (Advaita vs Viśiṣṭadvaita).
- 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks -- immortality + rebirth for a robust liberation.

MEMORY: Whenever a stem names a liberation-term, FIRST fix it on the §5A bench. Half the marks in this clause are lost to term-merging.

Vedantic Atman, Rebirth and Moksa: Advaita versus Visistadvaita

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks -- Advaita liberation + role of knowledge.
- 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks -- liberation without a real agent: Advaita vs

Visistadvaita -> this subtopic IS the answer.

- 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks -- immortality of soul w.r.t. Hindu tradition -> Vedantic atman is the centre of gravity.

MEMORY: 15-mark agent spine -> state the paradox -> Advaita's conventional- agency reply (sublation, not annihilation) -> Visistadvaita's real-jiva answer -> role of knowledge vs grace -> verdict fixing each conception of moksa.

Jain Jiva and Bondage: the Karmic-Matter Ladder

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2022 Q8(b), 15 marks -- nature of Soul and Bondage in Jainism -> this subtopic is the whole answer; deliver jiva metaphysics AND the karmic ladder.

- Feeds the parity bench (Subtopic 5) and the 2024 robust-liberation stem with the "perfected individuality" contrast.

MEMORY: 15-mark Jain spine -> jiva (eternal, conscious, body-sized) -> asrava -> bandha -> samvara -> nirjara -> kevala with ananta-catustaya -> distinguish from Advaita identity and Buddhist cessation -> note the interaction problem.

Cessation and Isolation: Nyaya Apavarga, Advaita Jivanmukti and Samkhya-Yoga Kaivalya

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks -- apavarga in Nyaya-Vaisesika (cessation, no bliss/ consciousness) -> half this subtopic.
- 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks -- jivanmukti in Advaita -> the prarabdha spun-wheel.
- Samkhya-Yoga kaivalya drill -> isolation, not identity or bliss; SK 62-63.

MEMORY: 10-mark apavarga spine -> Nyaya suffering-chain -> true knowledge reverses it -> cessation of pain AND consciousness -> contrast with Advaita bliss and Samkhya isolation -> verdict: liberation as cessation, not reward.

Paths to Liberation: Bhakti, and the Jnana-Karma-Bhakti Question

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks -- evaluate Bhakti as a pathway to liberation -> state the criterion of a "pathway" (accessibility, sufficiency, terminus), then judge.
- 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks -- are Knowledge, Action and Devotion the means? -> name the disagreement; do NOT harmonise.

MEMORY: 15-mark means spine -> production vs removal + saksat vs arad-upakaraka -> Mimamsa (karma) / Sankara (jnana, rejects samuccaya) / Ramanuja (graded samuccaya -> bhakti) / Gita 5.4-5 convergence -> verdict on function vs terminus.

Resurrection vs Rebirth vs Reincarnation; Inter-School Debates, Criticisms and Traps

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

- 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks -- Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation -> the rebirth-vs-reincarnation cut is delivered here (substance vs wider term).

- 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks -- immortality as presupposition of religion -> the resurrection route + Cullmann's opposition.
- Feeds every "distinguish the terms" demand across the corpus.

MEMORY: 20-mark trio spine -> define karma, rebirth, reincarnation separately -> interlock them -> contrast resurrection (one life, divine act, Cullmann) -> identity objections BOTH ways -> verdict: neither term is a version of another.

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 17 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Philosophy of Religion Paper II bank for 2018-2025. This clause owns exactly 17 primary parts (2018:2, 2019:1, 2020:2, 2021:3, 2022:3, 2023:2, 2024:2, 2025:2). Ownership discipline: Indian Philosophy Paper I questions that merely mention moksha or soul are NOT counted here.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: How far is it plausible to argue that the anti-theistic religions' stand on the concept of rebirth is philosophically significant?

Model solution

Thesis. The anti-theistic religions (Buddhism, and in its own way Jainism) are philosophically significant precisely because they show that rebirth is detachable both from a creator-God and from an immortal soul-substance.

- **Doctrine.** Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anatman*): what continues is a dependently arisen causal stream, not a transmigrating substance. Jainism has an eternal *jiva* but no God who administers karma; the moral law is self-regulating.

- **Significance (three claims).** (1) Karma needs no divine judge -- desert is discharged by an impersonal law, answering the problem of evil differently from theism. (2) Rebirth needs no immortal soul -- continuity, not substance, suffices (the flame-to-flame model). (3) Liberation (*nirvana*, *kevala*) requires neither grace nor union with God.

- **Objection -> reply.** If nothing permanent persists, who is reborn and who is liberated? Reply: the later stream is "neither the same nor wholly other"; moral responsibility rests on causal connectedness, not identity of substance.

Verdict. The stand is significant because it separates the *machinery* of karma-rebirth-liberation from theism and from soul-substance, proving that the Indian moral cosmos is not logically wedded to either.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it reads "significant" as a modal/structural claim (what rebirth does NOT require) rather than as praise, and names the exact anti-substantialist and anti-theistic points.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation.

Model solution

Thesis. Bhakti is a complete path to liberation in the theistic Vedantas and a preparatory discipline in Advaita; its philosophical contribution is structural -- it relocates liberation from achievement to reception.

- **Define the criterion.** A "pathway" must be assessed for accessibility, sufficiency and terminus -- not merely described.

- **Textual base.** *Gita* 18.66 (*carama-sloka*: abandon all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone), 9.22 and 9.32 on accessibility; *Bhagavata* 7.5.23 lists the nine limbs (*navadha bhakti*): *sravana*, *kirtana*, *smarana*, *pada-sevana*, *arcana*, *vandana*, *dasya*, *sakhya*, *atma-nivedana*.

- **Typology (marks lie here).** *para* vs *apara*; *vaidhi* vs *raganuga*; *saguna* (Tulsidas, Mira) vs *nirguna* (Kabir, Nanak) -- the latter showing

bhakti needs a personal focus, not an iconic form.

- **Systematic positions.** Ramanuja: bhakti as *dhruvanusmrti*, with *prapatti*

as the accessible alternative; grace decisive; *marjara* vs *markata* dispute on grace/effort. Madhva:

jnana-purvaka-sneha. Caitanya: *prema* as a fifth *purusartha*. Advaita: bhakti is *citta-suddhi*, preparatory not liberating.

- **Objection -> reply.** Love presupposes duality, so bhakti cannot deliver

Advaitic identity -> Advaita agrees and so classes it as means, not end; the theistic schools deny identity is the goal at all.

Verdict. Bhakti's significance is not emotional but structural: it makes moksha a matter of grace (reception) rather than qualification (achievement).

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- criterion-first evaluation, precise verse citation in order, the grace/effort dispute named, and the achievement-> reception thesis stated explicitly.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: State and explain the doctrines of Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism.

Model solution

Thesis. Karma, rebirth and reincarnation are linked but non-identical: karma is the mechanism, rebirth the field, and "reincarnation" a school-specific substantialist reading that Buddhism refuses. Define each before expounding.

- **Karma.** Act together with its unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*); classified as *sancita* (stored), *prarabdha* (ripening now) and *agami* (future). It is moral causation, not fatalism -- *purusakara* (effort) operates within *daiva*.

- **Rebirth.** *Punarjanma* within beginningless *samsara*; the subtle body (*suksma-sarira*) carries *samskaras* across lives. *Gita* 2.22 (worn-out

garments) and 9.21 (return from heaven when merit is exhausted) show even heaven is a within-*samsara* stage.

- **Reincarnation vs rebirth.** Reincarnation (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes a

SUBSTANTIAL soul re-entering a body (Vedanta, Nyaya, Jainism). Rebirth is the wider, neutral term and the ONLY correct one for Buddhism's *punarbhava* without a transmigrating self.

- **Contrast.** Resurrection -- one life, divine re-constitution, final judgement

(Cullmann's opposition of Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection).

- **Criticism -> reply.** Memory objection and victim-blaming risk; reply --

memory is not continuity, and karma explains without licensing social blame.

Verdict. Karma supplies the mechanism, rebirth the field, and reincarnation a substantialist reading of that field which Buddhism rejects.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it obeys "state AND explain" by defining all three separately, then interlocking them, and it nails the reincarnation/rebirth distinction the question is built to test.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: The concept of 'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion. Elaborate your answer.

Model solution

Thesis. Immortality functions as a basic presupposition of religion because most traditions require some post-mortem continuant to bear desert, judgement or liberation -- but the presupposition takes at least three different forms, and Buddhism shows it is not strictly necessary.

- **Why presupposed.** Moral seriousness (desert beyond this life), the hope of

liberation/salvation, and the meaningfulness of ritual for the dead all seem to need something that survives death.

- **Three forms.** (1) Greek/Platonic natural immortality of a simple soul; (2)

Semitic resurrection, where the psychosomatic person is re-constituted by God (not a natural property but a divine act

-- Cullmann, 1955); (3) Indian eternal *atman/jiva* transmigrating until liberation.

- **The counter-example.** Buddhism grounds desert and liberation on a causal

stream (*anatman*), so immortality is a common but not indispensable presupposition -- continuity is what is really required.

Verdict. "Immortality" is a widespread and structurally important presupposition of religion, but the deeper presupposition is CONTINUITY of a morally accountable subject, which Buddhism secures without an immortal soul.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it elaborates the claim (as asked) but refuses to overclaim, distinguishing the forms of the presupposition and citing the Buddhist limiting case.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Do you accept that Knowledge, Action and Devotion are the means to attain liberation in Indian tradition? Discuss.

Model solution

Thesis. Knowledge, action and devotion are all means to liberation, but means of DIFFERENT kinds; whether they are alternative, sequential or combined is settled by a prior question -- is liberation produced or uncovered?

- **Apparatus (deploy early).** Direct means (*saksat-sadhana*) vs remote aid (*arad-upakaraka*); means vs qualification (*adhikara*); production model vs

removal model of moksa.

- **Positions.** *Purva-Mimamsa*: karma alone (the *purvapaksa*). *Sankara*: jnana alone removes *avidya*; he rejects *jnana-karma-samuccaya*; karma and *upasana*

only purify (*sadhana-catustaya*; *sravana-manana-nididhyasana*). *Ramanuja*: karma -> jnana -> bhakti, with *prapatti* as the accessible alternative -- a graded *samuccaya*. *Madhva*: knowledge-grounded bhakti, *prasada* decisive.

- **The Gita's signal.** 5.4-5: only the immature call Samkhya (knowledge) and

Yoga (action) different -- which is why Sankara, Ramanuja and Tilak could each claim the text. Vivekananda's four yogas match temperament (psychological, not metaphysical, pluralism).

- **Objection -> reply.** "Convergence" is diplomatic mush -> reply: they converge

in FUNCTION (removing egoic self-appropriation) but diverge in TERMINUS (identity vs communion); say this rather than harmonising.

Verdict. Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jnana removes; their relation follows from each school's answer to whether liberation is produced or uncovered.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it names the disagreement instead of harmonising, and uses the production/removal cut to explain WHY schools differ.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Discuss the concept of immortality of soul with special reference to Hindu tradition.

Model solution

Thesis. In the Hindu tradition the immortality of the soul is affirmed across schools, but on different grounds and with different consequences for liberation; it is best read as the eternity of a continuity-bearer rather than one uniform doctrine.

- **Vedanta.** The *atman* is eternal and self-luminous; *Gita* 2.23 gives the

canonical image that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the embodied self. Advaita: *atman* = Brahman; Visistadvaita: the *jiva* is an eternal mode of God.

- **Nyaya-Vaisesika.** The self is an eternal substance, but consciousness is

adventitious to it -- hence *apavarga* is cessation of pain and of consciousness.

- **Samkhya-Yoga.** *Purusa* is eternal, plural, contentless witness, isolated by nature (*kevala*).
- **Comparison with the West.** Plato argues immortality a priori (Phaedo); the

Hindu case rests on scriptural testimony and substance-metaphysics, not on the Forms.

- **Critique -> reply.** The soul's simplicity does not entail indestructibility (Kant's paralogism), and there is no memory of past lives -> reply: continuity is carried by *samskaras* in the subtle body, distinct from psychological memory.

Verdict. Hindu "immortality of the soul" is the eternity of a continuity- bearer (*atman/jiva/purusa*), variously conceived, and it grounds -- but does not by itself deliver -- liberation.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it keeps "Hindu tradition" plural (Vedanta, Nyaya, Samkhya) instead of collapsing it, and cites the verified Gita 2.23 image.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation.

Model solution

Thesis. For Advaita, liberation (*moksa*) is the realisation of the *atman*'s identity with Brahman through the removal of ignorance (*avidya*); knowledge (*jnana*) is therefore the sole direct means.

- **Nature of liberation.** *Moksa* is not a producible effect but the eternally accomplished nature of the self, obscured by *avidya*. It comes as *jivanmukti*

(freedom while living, the body coasting on *prarabdha* like a spun wheel) and *videhamukti* (at the body's fall).

- **Role of knowledge.** Since bondage is ignorance, only knowledge can remove it, as light removes darkness. Sankara rejects *jnana-karma-samuccaya*; action and *upasana* generate *citta-suddhi* and the *sadhana-catustaya*, and knowledge matures through *sravana-manana-nididhyasana*.

- **Provenance (Griffiths).** Bondage is a beginningless superimposition (*adhyasa*) -- the rope taken for a snake -- so *moksa* is "not acquired but acknowledged"; knowledge only removes the error.

- **Objection -> reply.** If knowledge destroys karma, why does the body remain?

-> already-fructifying *prarabdha* is distinguished from accumulated and future karma.

Verdict. Advaitic liberation is a cognitive-existential awakening, and knowledge is the direct means because liberation is uncovered, not produced.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it answers BOTH obligations (the concept AND the role of knowledge), and grounds the "knowledge alone" claim in the removal model.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.

Model solution

Thesis. The doctrine of karma is an essential postulate of Hinduism because it supplies a self-regulating moral order that makes rebirth intelligible and desert just; it is defensible against fatalism and moral-luck objections but remains empirically unverifiable.

- **Statement.** Every morally qualified act leaves an unseen potency

(*adrsta/apurva*) that matures as pleasure or pain; *sancita/prarabdha/agami* classify the debt. Karma requires rebirth, since fruits mature beyond one life.

- **Why a postulate.** It grounds moral responsibility, explains the distribution

of fortune without a capricious deity, and secures the justice of *samsara*.

- **Evaluation.** Strength -- it is not fatalism: *purusakara* operates within *daiva*; present effort shapes *agami*.

Weakness -- unverifiability, and the

moral-luck/victim-blaming risk.

- **Objection -> reply.** Karma blames the sufferer -> reply: it EXPLAINS

distribution without LICENSING social judgement; compassion remains obligatory.

Verdict. Karma is postulated because it does indispensable work -- justice, responsibility, the intelligibility of rebirth -- but its warrant is inferential and moral, not empirical.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it both expounds AND evaluates (as asked), defending karma against fatalism while conceding unverifiability.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: "Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Critically examine with reference to Buddhism.

Model solution

Thesis. The claim that immortality of the soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth is false as stated: a persisting soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth but not NECESSARY, and Buddhism is the decisive counter-example.

- **The substantialist assumption.** In Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism an eternal *atman/jiva* is exactly what transmigrates, so there immortality is presupposed.

- **The Buddhist refutation.** Buddhism denies a permanent self (*anatman*) yet affirms rebirth (*punarbhava*): what continues is a dependently arisen causal

stream, illustrated by a flame passing candle to candle. Rebirth therefore requires CONTINUITY, not an unchanging substance.

- **Objection -> reply.** If no same agent persists, who is reborn and who reaps

the fruit? -> the later stream is "neither the same nor wholly other"; moral responsibility rests on causal connectedness.

Verdict. Immortality of a substantial soul is sufficient but not necessary for rebirth; what rebirth strictly needs is a continuity-bearer, and schools disagree only about whether that bearer must be a substance. Buddhism proves the point.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it delivers a precise MODAL verdict (sufficient not necessary) and uses Buddhism as a counter-example, not merely an exception.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Is it possible to have an idea of Liberation without the conception of a real agent? In this context, discuss the difference between Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita systems of thought.

Model solution

Thesis. An idea of liberation without a "real agent" is coherent, and the Advaita-Visistadvaita dispute is exactly a dispute over whether the liberated subject is an ultimately real individual agent.

- **The paradox.** If Advaita denies ultimate individuality, who is bound and who is liberated?

- **Advaita.** *Moksa* is the sublation of a MISTAKEN individuality, not the annihilation of an entity; conventional agency (*vyavaharika*) operates until

liberating knowledge removes the misidentification. The "agent" is real empirically, unreal absolutely -- so liberation needs no ultimately real agent.

- **Visistadvaita.** The *jiva* is a real, eternal mode of God, a genuine agent

throughout, bound by karma and freed into communion/service; it never becomes God. So it faces no agent-paradox but pays with irreducible plurality.

- **Objection -> reply.** Advaita's conventional agency looks ad hoc -> reply: the two-truths framework is doing principled work, distinguishing the standpoint of ignorance from that of realisation.

Verdict. Liberation without a real (ultimate) agent is coherent on Advaita and denied on Visistadvaita; the difference is not about liberation's possibility but about the ontological status of the one who is free.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it reframes the "real agent" question as the very axis dividing the two schools, giving each its own answer rather than blending.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2022 Q8(b), 15 marks

Question: Discuss the nature of Soul and Bondage according to Jainism.

Model solution

Thesis. In Jainism the soul (*jiva*) is an eternal, conscious substance whose bondage is the literal adhesion of fine karmic MATTER; liberation is the complete stoppage and shedding of that matter.

- **Nature of the soul.** Every living being is an eternal conscious *jiva*, of the size of the body it occupies, whose intrinsic nature is infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy (*ananta-catustaya*), currently obscured.

- **Bondage machinery.** Passions and action ATTRACT karmic particles (*asrava*); they BIND to the soul (*bandha*); restraint STOPS the influx (*samvara*); austerity SHEDS accumulated karma (*nirjara*); the freed *jiva* manifests its full qualities and rises to the summit of the universe (*siddhatva*).

- **Distinction.** Jain liberation PERFECTS individuality -- neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without a self. Jain *kevala* = omniscience, not Samkhya's contentless *kaivalya*.

- **Objection -> reply.** How does non-material consciousness interact with quasi-material karma? -> Jainism treats extension and embodiment as MODES of the *jiva* during bondage; the reply is contested but internally consistent.

Verdict. The Jain soul is eternal and intrinsically omniscient, and bondage/ liberation are a quasi-physical process of accretion and removal of karmic matter.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it delivers BOTH nouns the question names (soul AND bondage), with the *asrava-bandha-samvara-nirjara* machinery in order.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2023 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Critically examine Plato's apriori proofs for the immortality of the soul.

Model solution

Thesis. Plato's four Phaedo arguments make the soul's immortality suggestive but not demonstrable; assessed separately, each either reaches only pre-existence or rests on an undefended assumption.

- **(1) Opposites (cyclical).** Living and dead arise from each other, so souls persist between lives. *Assessment:* establishes recurrence, not the soul's indestructibility; the analogy from physical opposites is weak.

- **(2) Recollection (anamnesis).** We judge equal sticks by an Equality never perfectly given in sense, so the soul knew it before birth. *Assessment:* proves (at most) PRE-existence, not post-mortem survival.

- **(3) Affinity.** The soul is simple, invisible and akin to the Forms, so it does not decompose. *Assessment:* likeness is not identity; simplicity does not entail indestructibility.

- **(4) Form of Life.** The soul essentially brings Life and cannot admit its

opposite, death. **Assessment:** the strongest, but it assumes the soul is essentially life-giving -- the point at issue.

- **Objection -> reply.** Simmias' harmony analogy makes the soul a bodily attunement -> Plato replies the soul RULES the body and pre-exists it.

- **External critique.** Kant's paralogism: the soul is not a knowable substance.

Verdict. The arguments are mutually supporting rather than individually conclusive; they render immortality intelligible, not proven.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- "critically examine" is obeyed by FOUR separate assessments plus Simmias and Kant, not one summary verdict.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2023 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Examine the significance of the concept of rebirth in the theory of Karma.

Model solution

Thesis. Rebirth is not an optional appendage to the theory of karma but its enabling condition: without further lives, karma's justice -- fruits maturing beyond a single lifetime -- would be impossible.

- **The link.** Karma is act plus unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*); much of it (*sancita, agami*) matures only in future lives. Rebirth is the FIELD in which

those fruits ripen, so karmic desert requires a continued series.

- **Continuity-bearer.** In substantial systems the subtle body carries *samskaras* across births; in Buddhism a causal stream does the same work without a soul -- showing rebirth needs continuity, not necessarily substance.

- **Scriptural note.** *Gita* 9.21: those who exhaust their merit "return to the world of mortals" -- even heaven is a within-*samsara* stage, confirming that desert keeps the wheel turning.

- **Objection -> reply.** Rebirth is unverifiable and morally hazardous -> reply: untestability is shared with resurrection, and explanatory karma does not license blaming the sufferer.

Verdict. Rebirth is significant in karma theory as the mechanism of discharge: it is what makes moral desert coherent when one life is too short to settle it.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it explains the FUNCTION of rebirth within karma (discharge of desert), not just the fact of it, and adds the continuity point.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2024 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the concept of liberation (*Apavarga*) according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

Model solution

Thesis. For Nyaya-Vaisesika, liberation (*apavarga*) is the absolute cessation of pain together with the qualities -- including consciousness -- that sustain embodied experience; it is a negative state, not positive bliss.

- **The suffering-chain.** Suffering arises through false knowledge -> defect -> activity -> rebirth -> suffering; true knowledge (*tattva-jnana*) reverses the chain from its root.

- **What liberation is.** The self is an eternal substance to which consciousness is ADVENTITIOUS (arising only through contact with mind and body). In *apavarga* the self persists, but stripped of the nine special qualities including cognition, pleasure and pain -- hence liberation is the end of experience, not its perfection.

- **Distinction.** *Apavarga* differs from positive heavenly pleasure, and from Advaita's blissful *moksa*; it resembles cessation more than fulfilment.

- **Objection -> reply.** A consciousness-less liberation seems undesirable ->

reply: Nyaya honestly offers freedom from pain, not a reward; to promise bliss would misdescribe the self.

Verdict. *Apavarga* is the cessation of pain and of the very consciousness that makes pain possible -- the sharpest Indian statement of liberation as release rather than beatitude.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it refuses to sentimentalise *apavarga* as bliss, grounding "no consciousness" in the adventitious-consciousness doctrine.

Solved PYQ 15 - 2024 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Is it necessary to adhere to the notions of immortality of soul and rebirth in order to have a robust conception of liberation? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Model solution

Thesis. A robust conception of liberation requires a continuity-bearer that can be bound across lives and then freed -- but it does NOT require an immortal soul-substance; Buddhism shows liberation is coherent on a causal-continuity model.

- **The apparent necessity.** Liberation is exit from bondage-across-lives, so it seems to presuppose (a) rebirth, and (b) something immortal that is liberated. Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism satisfy both with an eternal *atman/jiva*.
- **The Buddhist case.** *Anatman* + *pratityasamutpada* deliver rebirth and *nirvana* with no permanent self: the stream that was bound is the stream that ceases to crave. So "immortality of soul" is sufficient, not necessary.
- **What IS necessary.** A continuity that can carry desert and then END. Call it substance (substantialists) or stream (Buddhism); either grounds a robust liberation.

- **Objection -> reply.** Without an immortal self, liberation liberates no one -> reply: it liberates the causal series from craving; identity of substance is not required for the coherence of release.

Verdict. Immortality and rebirth are the standard scaffolding of liberation but not its logical minimum; the minimum is a morally continuous subject whose bondage can cease -- which Buddhism secures without an eternal soul.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it gives reasons BOTH ways (as the stem demands), then fixes the exact modal minimum, using Buddhism as the load-bearing case.

Solved PYQ 16 - 2025 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Discuss the nature of embodied liberation (*jīvanmukti*) with reference to Advaita Vedānta.

Model solution

Thesis. *Jivanmukti* in Advaita Vedanta is liberation WHILE EMBODIED: the knower of Brahman is free the moment ignorance is destroyed, though the body continues on residual momentum until death.

- **The doctrine.** *Moksa* is realising *atman* = Brahman by ending *avidya*. Since bondage is ignorance, liberating knowledge frees IMMEDIATELY -- one need not wait for death.
- **Why the body remains.** Already-fructifying *prarabdha* karma sustains the body, like a potter's wheel that spins on after the hand is withdrawn; accumulated (*sancita*) and future (*agami*) karma are burnt by knowledge. *Videhamukti* follows at the body's fall.
- **Character of the jivanmukta.** Free from egoic appropriation, acting without binding karma, established in Brahman-consciousness now.
- **Objection -> reply.** If knowledge destroys karma, why any embodiment at all? -> the distinction of *prarabdha* from *sancita/agami* answers exactly this.

Verdict. *Jivanmukti* shows Advaitic liberation is a present cognitive- existential transformation, not a post-mortem place or reward -- freedom is realised, not relocated.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it fixes *jivanmukti* against *videhamukti* and > explains the residual body by *prarabdha*, the exact discriminator examiners want.

Solved PYQ 17 - 2025 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: Is the concept of immortality of soul a necessary condition for Rebirth? Discuss with reference to the Bhagavad Gītā.

Model solution

Thesis. With reference to the *Bhagavad Gita*, immortality of the soul is presented as the presupposition of rebirth: precisely because the embodied self is imperishable, it "casts off worn-out bodies and enters new ones". Yet, read philosophically, this shows immortality is sufficient for rebirth, not universally necessary.

- **The Gita's teaching.** 2.23 -- weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the self; 2.22 -- the self changes bodies as a person changes worn-out garments. Rebirth here PRESUPPOSES the deathless *atman*.

- **The mechanism.** Driven by karma, the imperishable self takes new embodiments within *samsara*; 9.21 shows even heavenly sojourn ends in return.

- **The wider verdict.** The Gita's model is substantialist, so for IT immortality is necessary. But Buddhism affirms rebirth without an immortal soul, so the necessity is school-relative: the Gita states a sufficient condition, not a law binding every rebirth theory.

- **Objection -> reply.** Does the Gita PROVE immortality? -> No; it ASSERTS it as scriptural teaching and illustrates it (the garment image is illustration, not demonstration).

Verdict. In the Gita, immortality of the soul is the necessary ground of rebirth; across the traditions, it is sufficient but not necessary -- Buddhism is the reservation the honest answer records.

MEMORY: Why this earns marks -- it stays faithful to the NAMED text (Gita verses) while still delivering the modal verdict and the Buddhist reservation.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original question | Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion | 10 marks | answer in ~150 words

Question: Distinguish rebirth from reincarnation, and explain why the distinction is decisive for Buddhism.

Model solution

Thesis. Rebirth is the wider, more neutral term; reincarnation is the narrower term that assumes a substantial soul re-entering flesh -- which is why Buddhism accepts rebirth but not reincarnation.

- **Reincarnation** (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes an enduring soul-substance that passes from body to body; it fits Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism.

- **Rebirth** (*punarjanma/punarbhava*) names only re-becoming within *samsara*, and can be cashed out with or without a substance.

- **Why decisive for Buddhism.** Buddhism affirms *punarbhava* while denying a permanent self (*anatman*); what continues is a dependently arisen causal stream (flame-to-flame), "neither the same nor wholly other". To call this "reincarnation" would smuggle back the very soul-substance Buddhism denies.

Verdict. Use "rebirth" as the genus and reserve "reincarnation" for the substantialist species; only then is Buddhist *punarbhava* correctly described.

Original Mains 2

Original question | Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion | 15 marks | answer in ~250 words

Question: Examine whether 'liberation' can be treated as a single concept across the Indian schools.

Model solution

Thesis. 'Liberation' is a family-resemblance term, not a single concept: once the school-specific destinations are separated, the apparent Indian consensus turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering incompatible states.

- **The parity bench.** *Moksa* (Advaita) is realised identity with Brahman; *moksa* (Visistadvaita) is eternal communion with God; *apavarga* (Nyaya) is cessation of pain AND of consciousness; *kaivalya* (Samkhya-Yoga) is the isolation of contentless consciousness; *kevala/siddhatva* (Jain) is perfected omniscient individuality; *nirvana* (Buddhism) is the cessation of craving with

no self affirmed.

- **The consciousness test.** These states differ precisely on what survives:

Nyaya keeps a self but no consciousness; Advaita keeps non-dual bliss; Samkhya keeps contentless awareness; Jainism keeps omniscience; Buddhism affirms no self. A single concept cannot span "no consciousness" and "infinite bliss".

- **What they share.** Only a formal core: cessation of bondage and exit from *samsara*. That is a family resemblance, not a common essence.

- **Objection -> reply.** Perhaps all are "freedom from suffering"? Reply: even this masks a production/removal split and the identity/isolation divide.

Verdict. Treat 'liberation' as a genus with irreducibly different species; fixing the exact term against the parity bench is the first task in any answer.

Original Mains 3

Original question | Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion | 20 marks | answer in ~400 words

Question: Compare the Western resurrection tradition and the Indian rebirth tradition on the problem of personal identity across death.

Model solution

Thesis. Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions and face the identity problem from opposite directions; neither is a version of the other, and on both the question "is the later being the SAME?" remains unresolved.

- **Two structures.** Resurrection (Hebrew-Christian-Islamic) is ONE life: the person is a psychosomatic unity, so survival needs God to re-constitute the whole person, and history ends in judgement. Rebirth (Indian) is a beginningless series in which karma matures across lives until liberation. Oscar Cullmann (1955) argues Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are theologically OPPOSED, not complementary.

- **Identity for resurrection.** The gap problem (what exists between death and resurrection?) and the re-assembly ("cannibal") problem (shared atoms) threaten bodily continuity. Standard replies: Aquinas -- the rational soul is the FORM of the body and secures continuity; van Inwagen -- God preserves a core of the body or leaves a simulacrum; Hick -- an exact, unique psychophysical replica, continuous in memory and character, is the same person for all that matters. The duplication objection (God could make two) says the criterion is then not identity.

- **Book support.** Lynne Rudder Baker ("Death and the Afterlife", Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion) sets out four candidate criteria -- same soul, same body, same composite, or continuity of memory -- and surveys Origen's "seed", Augustine's re-collected "statue" and Aquinas's soul-as-form; Bernard Williams's reduplication argument and H. H. Price's image-world sharpen the difficulty.

- **Identity for rebirth.** The memory objection (no recollection of prior lives)

is met by distinguishing psychological memory from metaphysical continuity and appealing to latent *samskaras*; in Buddhism identity is dropped altogether in favour of a causal stream "neither the same nor wholly other".

- **Contrast.** Resurrection keeps the body essential; rebirth discards it like a garment (*Gīta* 2.22). Resurrection needs a divine agent; rebirth needs only the self-regulating law of karma.

Verdict. Resurrection asks how an essentially embodied person can survive; rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when one life is too short. Both leave the sameness of the later being contested -- for resurrection because of the gap and duplication, for rebirth because of the missing memory and (in Buddhism) the deliberate abandonment of numerical identity.

CANONICAL EXAM APPARATUS (PRESERVED VERBATIM)

The examiner apparatus below is reproduced verbatim from the canonical Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md (headings demoted, navigation links stripped). It is preserved intact so that no canonical depth - foundational statement bank, applied-question drills, PYQ-mapped model-answer skeletons, the keyword and statement bank, the corpus depth delta, PYQ routing, answer architecture, directive decoder, graded verdict ladder, factual / quotation discipline, link-outs and sources - is lost in the layered reorganisation.

Foundational Statement Bank

1. FACT: *Bhagavad Gītā* 2.23 presents the self as not destructible by weapons or elements; translations vary.
2. FACT: Plato's recollection argument infers pre-existence from knowledge not exhausted by deficient sensible instances.
3. FACT: Flame-to-flame is a standard illustration of Buddhist causal continuity without numerical identity.
4. FACT: *Jīvanmukti* means liberation while embodied life continues.
5. FACT: Nyāya apavarga is final cessation of suffering and the qualities that sustain embodied experience.

Applied-Question Drills

1. **[Plato]** "Critically examine Plato's a priori proofs for immortality." (2023, 20m) -> §1. 2. **[Buddhism]** "Immortality of soul is necessary for rebirth.' Examine w.r.t. Buddhism." (2022) -> §2. 3. **[Nyāya]** "Concept of liberation (apavarga) in Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika." (2024) -> §3. 4. **[Advaita]** "Nature of jīvanmukti in Advaita Vedānta." (2025) -> §3. 5. **[Necessity]** "Is immortality+rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024) -> §2-3. 6. **[Bhakti]** "Evaluate Bhakti as a pathway to liberation." (2018, 15m) -> §8.6. 7. **[Three means]** "Are Knowledge, Action and Devotion the means to liberation?" (2020, 15m) -> §8.7 - name the disagreement, do not harmonise. 8. **[Karma trio]** "Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism." (2019, 20m) -> §8.8 - **distinguish rebirth from reincarnation explicitly**. 9. **[Immortality presupposition]** "'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion." (2020, 10m) -> §1 + §8.8 (resurrection route + Buddhist counter-example). 10. **[Agent]** "Liberation without a real agent? Advaita vs Viśiṣṭādvaita." (2022, 15m) -> §8.2 + §8.7 apparatus. 11. **[Kaivalya]** "Sāṃkhya-Yoga's conception of liberation." -> §8.9 - isolation, not identity or bliss.

PYQ-Mapped Model-Answer Skeletons

6.1 - "Is immortality of the soul a necessary condition for rebirth? (w.r.t. Buddhism)" (2022, 10m)

Intro : substantialist assumption - a soul must persist to transmigrate.
 Body : Vedānta/Nyāya/Jain - YES, eternal ātman/jīva is what is reborn;
 Buddhism - NO: anātman; what continues is a causal stream (pratītyasamutpāda),
 rebirth like flame-to-flame, not a soul.
 Assess: rebirth needs CONTINUITY, not necessarily an unchanging soul.
 Concl : immortality is sufficient but not necessary - Buddhism proves the point.

6.2 - "Nature of jīvanmukti in Advaita Vedānta." (2025, 10m)

Intro : Advaita - mokṣa is realising ātman = Brahman; ends avidyā.
 Body : jīvanmukti = liberated WHILE living; jñāna destroys ignorance now;
 body persists by prārabdha karma (spun-wheel) -> videhamukti at death.
 Assess: liberation is a cognitive-existential transformation, not a post-mortem reward.
 Concl : freedom is present realisation, not a future place.

6.3 - "Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation." (2018, 15m)

Intro : bhakti = loving devotion to a personal God, held to be a DIRECT means of mokṣa.
Body : textual base - Gītā 18.66 (carama-śloka), 9.22; Bhāgavata 7.5.23 navadhā bhakti;
Nārada/Śaṇḍilya Bhakti Sūtras.
typology - parā/aparā; vaidhī/rāgānugā; saguṇa (Tulsīdās, Mīrā) vs nirguṇa (Kabīr, Nānak).
systematic - Rāmānuja (dhruvānusr̥ti + prapatti; grace); mārjāra vs markāṭa nyāya;
Madhva (jñāna-pūrvaka-sneha); Vallabha (puṣṭi); Caitanya (prema as fifth puruṣārtha);
Advaita (preparatory - citta-śuddhi, not direct means).
Assess: strengths - accessibility across caste/gender/language; whole-person engagement;
grace answers the incapacity of a beginninglessly bound jīva.
objections - love presupposes duality; emotionalism; grace vs effort; requires a personal
God.
Concl : philosophically, bhakti relocates liberation from achievement to RECEPTION - that, not
emotion, is its contribution.

6.4 - "Are Knowledge, Action and Devotion the means to liberation in Indian tradition?" (2020, 15m)

Intro : the real question is whether they are alternative, sequential or combined.
Tools : sākṣāt-sādhana vs ārād-upakāraka; means vs adhikāra; PRODUCTION vs REMOVAL model of mokṣa.
Body : Mīmāṃsā - karma alone (the pūrvapakṣa).
Śaṅkara - jñāna alone removes avidyā; rejects jñāna-karma-samuccaya; karma/upāsanā only
purify (sādhana-catuṣṭaya; śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana).
Rāmānuja - karma -> jñāna -> bhakti, with prapatti as the accessible alternative.
Madhva - knowledge-grounded bhakti; prasāda decisive.
Gītā 5.4-5 - only the immature call Sāṃkhya and Yoga different; hence Śaṅkara, Rāmānuja
and Tilak could each claim the text.
Vivekananda - four yogas matched to temperament (psychological, not metaphysical,
pluralism).
Assess: they converge in FUNCTION (dismantling egoic appropriation) and diverge in TERMINUS
(identity vs communion) - say this rather than harmonising.
Concl : all three are means, of different kinds - karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jñāna removes.

6.5 - "Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism." (2019, 20m)

Intro : three linked but non-identical concepts - define each before expounding.
B1 : Karma - act + its unseen potency (adr̥ṣṭa/apūrvā); sañcita / prārabdha / āgāmi;
moral causation, not fatalism (puruṣakāra vs daiva).
B2 : Rebirth - punarjanma within beginningless saṃsāra; subtle body carries saṃskāras;
Gītā 2.22 (garments) and 9.21 (return from heaven when merit is exhausted).
B3 : Reincarnation vs rebirth - reincarnation presupposes a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-enfleshed
(Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism); rebirth is the wider term and the only correct one for
Buddhism's punarbhava without a transmigrating self.
Contrast: resurrection - one life, divine re-constitution, final judgement (Cullmann's opposition
of Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection).
Crit : memory objection; unverifiability; victim-blaming risk - and the replies.
Concl : karma supplies the mechanism, rebirth the field, and "reincarnation" a school-specific
substantialist reading that Buddhism refuses.

Keyword and Statement Bank

Keywords: FACT: immortality · pre-existence · recollection · affinity · Form of Life · resurrection · psychosomatic unity
· replica theory · gap problem · re-assembly objection · ātman · jīva · subtle body (*sūkṣma/linga-śarīra*) · karma ·
saṃsāra · *punarjanma* · *punarbhava* · reincarnation vs rebirth · *anātman* · causal continuum · *pratītyasamutpāda* ·
saṃskāra/vāsanā · apavarga · mokṣa · nirvāṇa · kaivalya · *kevala-jñāna* · *jīvanmukti* · *videhamukti* · *videha-kaivalya* ·
prārabdha · *saṃvara* · *nirjarā* · bhakti · *navadhā bhakti* · *vaidhī/rāgānugā* · saguṇa/nirguṇa bhakti · *prapatti/śaraṇāgati*
· *mārjāra/markāṭa-nyāya* · *puṣṭi-mārga* · *prema-bhakti* · *citta-śuddhi* · *upāsanā* · *sādhana-catuṣṭaya* ·
śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana · *jñāna-karma-samuccaya* · *sākṣāt-sādhana/ārād-upakāraka* · *niṣkāma-karma* ·
aviveka · *viveka-khyāti* · *satkāryavāda* · threefold *duḥkha* · *citta-vṛtti-nirodha* · *kleśa* · *aṣṭāṅga* ·
dharma-megha-samādhi · *pratiprasava* · *citi-śakti* · *Īśvara-praṇidhāna*.

Safe formulations: ANALYSIS: "Rebirth requires an account of continuity, not necessarily an immortal substance." ·
"Liberation is a family-resemblance term: cessation, isolation, identity-realisation and perfected individuality must not
be conflated." · "Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jñāna removes - the dispute over their relation is really a dispute
over whether liberation is produced or uncovered." · "Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions; neither is a
version of the other."

Corpus-Driven Depth Delta

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** This is the largest Religion owner: 17 of 112 parts across 2018-2025.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** Older papers add anti-theistic rebirth, bhakti as liberation-path,
karma-rebirth-reincarnation, immortality as religious presupposition, Hindu soul and Advaitic liberation, and

jñāna-karma-bhakti comparison.

- **WRONG: Trap / answer consequence:** Do not make a permanent soul logically necessary for every rebirth theory; distinguish continuity, reincarnation, resurrection, liberation and the metaphysics of the agent.

PYQ Routing Table (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: 17 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper II corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(b)	10 marks	How far is it plausible to argue that the anti-theistic religions' stand on the concept of rebirth is philosophically significant?
2018	Q7(c)	15 marks	Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation.
2019	Q8(a)	20 marks	State and explain the doctrines of Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism.
2020	Q5(b)	10 marks	The concept of 'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion. Elaborate your answer.
2020	Q8(c)	15 marks	Do you accept that Knowledge, Action and Devotion are the means to attain liberation in Indian tradition? Discuss.
2021	Q6(a)	20 marks	Discuss the concept of immortality of soul with special reference to Hindu tradition.
2021	Q6(b)	15 marks	Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation.
2021	Q8(b)	15 marks	Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.
2022	Q5(c)	10 marks	"Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Critically examine with reference to Buddhism.
2022	Q7(b)	15 marks	Is it possible to have an idea of Liberation without the conception of a real agent? In this context, discuss the difference between Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita systems of thought.
2022	Q8(b)	15 marks	Discuss the nature of Soul and Bondage according to Jainism.
2023	Q6(a)	20 marks	Critically examine Plato's apriori proofs for the immortality of the soul.
2023	Q7(b)	15 marks	Examine the significance of the concept of rebirth in the theory of Karma.
2024	Q5(c)	10 marks	Discuss the concept of liberation (Apavarga) according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.
2024	Q6(a)	20 marks	Is it necessary to adhere to the notions of immortality of soul and rebirth in order to have a robust conception of liberation? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.
2025	Q5(d)	10 marks	Discuss the nature of embodied liberation (jīvanmukti) with reference to Advaita Vedānta.
2025	Q7(c)	15 marks	Is the concept of immortality of soul a necessary condition for Rebirth? Discuss with reference to the Bhagavad Gītā.

See the Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

Answer Architecture (10 / 15 / 20 Marks)

10 marks

Define the disputed necessity -> give substantialist position -> Buddhist/Jain/Nyāya discriminator as required -> objection -> precise verdict on necessary vs sufficient.

15 marks

State doctrine and continuity-bearer -> causal sequence -> canonical example -> nearest school contrast -> objection/reply -> identify exact conception of liberation.

20 marks

Separate immortality, rebirth and liberation -> reconstruct two rival models -> personal-identity and moral-responsibility objections -> school replies -> graded conclusion on continuity without conflation.

Directive Decoder

Directive	Examiner is buying	Structural consequence	Live example
Is X a necessary condition for Y?	A modal verdict - necessary / sufficient / neither	Give the substantialist "yes", then the Buddhist counter-example, then the exact modal claim	2022 Q5(c); 2025 Q7(c); 2024 Q6(a)
Discuss with reference to [named text/school]	Fidelity to <i>that</i> source	The Gītā question must cite Gītā verses, not generic Vedānta	2025 Q7(c) <i>w.r.t. the Bhagavad Gītā</i>
Critically examine [thinker]'s proofs	Each argument separately assessed	Four Platonic arguments = four mini-assessments, not one summary	2023 Q6(a) Plato
Elucidate... and explain the role of...	Two obligations - obey both	Half the answer on the concept, half on the specified role	2021 Q6(b) liberation + role of knowledge
Do you accept that...? Discuss	An explicit acceptance/rejection with reasons	Position first; then evidence; then the strongest contrary case	2020 Q8(c) knowledge/action/devotion
Evaluate the concept of X as a pathway	Assessment of <i>efficacy</i> , not description	State the criterion of a "pathway" - accessibility, sufficiency, terminus	2018 Q7(c) bhakti
State and explain the doctrines of A, B and C	Three defined doctrines and their <i>relations</i>	Define each separately, then show how they interlock	2019 Q8(a) karma/rebirth/reincarnation
Discuss the nature of A and B according to [school]	Two nouns, both delivered	Jain "soul and bondage" needs <i>jīva</i> metaphysics and <i>āsrava/bandha</i>	2022 Q8(b)

MEMORY: **Rule:** the moment a question names a **term of liberation** (mokṣa/apavarga/kaivalya/nirvāṇa/jīvanmukti), your first job is to fix that term against the §5A bench. Half the marks in this clause are lost to term-merging.

Graded Verdict Ladder

Band	What the script contains	Typical fault
Weak (≈40%)	"The soul is eternal and is reborn until liberated"	All schools merged; liberation terms used as synonyms
Average (≈50%)	Correct school-wise definitions	No argument reconstruction; Buddhism handled as an exception, not a counter-example
Good (≈60%)	Continuity-bearer identified per school; one objection answered	Necessary/sufficient distinction unstated
Strong (≈65-70%)	Modal verdict precise; §5A distinctions live; Western comparator (Plato / resurrection) used	Bhakti or the three-means dispute reduced to a list
Top (≈70%+)	All the above + a discriminating distinction (production vs removal model; <i>sākṣāt</i> vs <i>ārād-upakāra</i> ; SK 62-63 misattribution; replica theory) + a statement of what would falsify the position	-

Graded-verdict templates:

- ANALYSIS: *Necessity stem:* "Immortality of a substantial soul is **sufficient** for rebirth but not **necessary**: Buddhism secures re-becoming through causal continuity alone. What rebirth actually requires is a **continuity-bearer**, and schools disagree only about whether that bearer must be a substance."

- ANALYSIS: *Means stem*: "All three are means of different kinds. Which is the *direct* means is settled by a prior metaphysical question - whether liberation is produced or uncovered - and every school's answer follows from its answer to that."
- ANALYSIS: *Liberation-concept stem*: "The term names a family, not a state. Once *apavarga*, *kaivalya*, *mokṣa* and *nirvāṇa* are separated, the apparent Indian consensus on liberation turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering four incompatible destinations."

Factual and Quotation Discipline

Item	Status	Safe use
Plato's four arguments	FACT: <i>Phaedo</i> - cyclical, recollection, affinity, final (Form of Life) argument	Assess each separately; Simmias' harmony objection is in the same dialogue
Gītā 2.22 (garments), 2.23 (weapons/fire/water/wind), 9.21, 18.66	FACT: Verified chapter/verse	Translations vary - paraphrase, or quote a named translation
Gītā 5.4-5 (<i>bālāḥ</i> , not <i>paṇḍitāḥ</i>)	FACT:	The single best warrant for the convergence reading
<i>Bhāgavata Purāṇa</i> 7.5.23 (<i>navadhā bhakti</i>)	FACT:	Give all nine limbs, in order
<i>Nārada Bhakti Sūtra</i> / <i>Śaṇḍilya Bhakti Sūtra</i>	FACT: Texts exist and define bhakti as supreme love/attachment	Do not attribute a date or an author-identification CAUTION:
<i>Vivekacūḍāmaṇi</i> 's definition of bhakti	CAUTION: Ascription to Śaṃkara is disputed	Say "the Advaita tradition", not "Śaṃkara wrote"
<i>Mārjāra</i> /markaṭa-nyāya	FACT: Standard Śrīvaiṣṇava Teṅkalai/Vaḍakalai illustration	Use for the grace-effort problem
<i>Sāṃkhya-kārikā</i> 1 (threefold <i>duḥkha</i>), 62-63 (no puruṣa is bound), 67-68 (potter's wheel)	FACT: Verified kārikā numbers	The 62-63 doctrine is the highest-value item in the module
<i>Yoga-sūtra</i> 1.2, 1.3, 1.24, 2.3, 4.29, 4.34	FACT: Verified sūtra numbers	1.24 proves Yoga's Īśvara is not a creator
Flame-to-flame / milk-to-curd	FACT: Standard Buddhist illustrations (e.g. <i>Milindapañha</i> uses the lamp)	Illustration, never proof
Replica theory	FACT: John Hick , <i>Philosophy of Religion / Death and Eternal Life</i>	Present it as a <i>thought-experiment defence</i> , and give the duplication objection
<i>Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?</i>	FACT: Oscar Cullmann (1955)	The canonical statement that the two are opposed
"Potter's wheel" for <i>prārabdha</i>	FACT: Used in both Advaita and Sāṃkhya	Note the metaphysics differs even though the image is shared

Link-Outs to Related Topics

- Notions of God - the God-soul relation that fixes what liberation can be
- Problem of Evil - karma, desert and the distribution of suffering
- Religion without God - Yoga's non-creator Īśvara; Jain and Buddhist soteriology without a deity
- Religious Experience - *aparokṣānubhūti* as the cognitive event of liberation
- Paper I self/liberation theme
- Paper I: Sāṃkhya - 25 tattvas, *satkāryavāda*, *viveka-khyāti* -> §8.9
- Paper I: Yoga - *citta-vṛtti-nirodha*, *kleśas*, *aṣṭāṅga*, *kaivalya* -> §8.9
- Paper I: Buddhism
- Paper I: Jainism
- Paper I: Vedānta

- Paper I: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika - *apavarga* and the eternal self-substance
- Philosophy of Religion PYQ Bank, 2018-2025

Sources

- Plato, *Phaedo*.
- *Bhagavad Gītā*, especially Chapters 2, 5, 9 and 18; *Bhāgavata Purāṇa* 7.5.
- *Sāṃkhya-kārikā* of Īśvarakṛṣṇa; Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*, with the classical commentaries.
- John Hick, *Philosophy of Religion* and *Death and Eternal Life*; Oscar Cullmann, *Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?*
- Peter van Inwagen on the possibility of resurrection.
- S. C. Chatterjee & D. M. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*; C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*; S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vols. I-II.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Advanced-dossier reconciliation - [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

The dossier adds four bounded refinements: substance-self versus psychological or Buddhist causal continuity; the memory objection to rebirth; positive-perfection versus cessation accounts of liberation; and the Advaita *prārabdha* problem after liberating knowledge. These refinements strengthen a 15/20-marker but must remain subordinate to the owner doctrines. Teleportation, brain-split cases and fringe reincarnation literature are deliberately excluded as low-return.

The Six Survival-Terms and the Necessity Question

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

The necessity question is a modal question, so answer it with modal vocabulary.

ANALYSIS: Is immortality of a substantial soul NECESSARY for rebirth? In the substantialist systems (Vedānta, Nyāya, Jainism) an eternal ātman or jīva is exactly what transmigrates, so there immortality is presupposed. But Buddhism secures re-becoming through a causal stream alone. So a persisting soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth, not NECESSARY -- Buddhism is the decisive counter-case.

ANALYSIS: Is rebirth necessary for liberation? Liberation is defined as exit from the cycle, so it presupposes bondage-across-lives and something that is freed. Substantial systems answer yes; Buddhism shows nirvāṇa is coherent even without an eternal soul, so "a robust conception of liberation" does not logically require an immortal substance -- only a continuity that can end.

Because the several liberation-words name different destinations, "liberation" behaves like a family-resemblance term rather than one fixed state: identity (Advaita), communion (Viśiṣṭadvaita), cessation (Nyāya *apavarga*, Buddhist nirvāṇa), isolation (Sāṃkhya-Yoga *kaivalya*) and perfected individuality (Jain *kevala*) share a family label but not a single content.

WRONG: Treating the one-screen map as one school's doctrine. It is a comparative scaffold; each cell must be cashed out in that school's own terms.

Immortality of the Soul: Plato's Four Proofs and the Western Critique

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Grade the four arguments separately, because the examiner does.

ANALYSIS: The cyclical and recollection arguments establish only pre-existence; they do not yet prove post-mortem survival. Plato needs the affinity and Form-of-Life arguments to bridge the second direction, and even these rest on the assumption that what is simple cannot decompose -- simplicity does not by itself entail indestructibility. Kant's paralogism formalises the complaint: the soul is not a knowable substance, so its permanence cannot be demonstrated.

ANALYSIS: Simmias' harmony objection (same dialogue) makes the soul an attunement of the body, which would perish with it. Plato replies that the soul rules the body rather than depending on it, and that recollection presupposes a soul already in existence before the body -- an attunement cannot pre-exist its instrument.

BOOK: In "Death and the Afterlife" (Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion), Lynne Rudder Baker frames Plato's position as NATURAL immortality -- the soul is deathless by its own nature and death merely releases it -- and contrasts it with the Semitic view, where survival is a divine ACT, not a property of the soul. This is why Plato belongs on the "immortality" side and resurrection on the other.

The Indian comparison earns marks: atman (Vedanta), jiva (Jain) and the Nyaya self are all eternal, but by scriptural testimony and substance-metaphysics, not by Plato's Forms. The Gita 2.23 image (weapons, fire, water, wind cannot destroy the self) is a canonical illustration -- paraphrase it; do not treat it as proof.

Rebirth: Karma, Samsara and the Buddhist Challenge

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: Rebirth is the mechanism by which karmic debts are discharged. The 2023 question ("significance of rebirth in the theory of Karma") is really asking: why does karma REQUIRE rebirth? Because desert outruns a single life.

ANALYSIS: Then comes the Buddhist twist. Buddhism denies a permanent soul (anatman) yet affirms rebirth: what is reborn is not a self but a causal continuum of momentary states, a flame passing candle to candle. So rebirth requires CONTINUITY, not necessarily an unchanging soul -- immortality is sufficient but not necessary. Say exactly this for 2022 Q5(c) and 2025 Q7(c).

Guard two objections in advance:

WRONG: Reading karma as fatalism. The tradition insists on purusakara (personal effort) operating within daiva (the given): prarabdha fixes the hand you are dealt, agami is the hand you are now playing.

ANALYSIS: The moral-desert or "victim-blaming" objection says karma licenses blaming the sufferer for an unverifiable past fault. Reply: karma EXPLAINS distribution without LICENSING social judgement; compassion remains obligatory, and the explanatory claim is separable from any prescriptive one.

Provenance discipline: the Gita's garment image (2.22) and the pitryana teaching (9.21, merit exhausted -> return to the mortal world) are verified verses -- use them as illustration; even heaven is a within-samsara stage, not resurrection.

Buddhist Rebirth Without a Soul: Anatman and Causal Continuity

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

The engine is dependent origination (pratityasamutpada): all conditioned factors are impermanent; no aggregate is a self; craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; so continuity occurs without an unchanging owner.

ANALYSIS: The standard objection -- "if no same agent persists, who receives the karmic fruit?" -- is answered by the causal-descent formula: the later stream is neither the same nor wholly other than the earlier. Moral responsibility needs causal connectedness, not substance-identity.

WRONG: Calling anatman nihilism. Buddhism denies an independent, permanent self, not conventional persons or the reality of consequences.

BOOK: Philip L. Quinn, writing on religious diversity in the Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion, contrasts the Christian hope of UNION WITH GOD with Buddhist nirvana, which he characterises as the ceasing-to-be of the individual self rather than its perfection -- precisely the anti-substantialist point the 2018 "anti-theistic religions" question rewards.

This subtopic also carries the 2018 Q5(b) demand: the philosophical significance of the anti-theistic (Buddhist, Jain) stand on rebirth is that it PROVES rebirth is separable from theism and from an immortal soul -- a self-regulating moral order needs neither a God who judges nor a substance that transmigrates.

Liberation Across Schools: the Parity Bench

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: Jivanmukti (Advaita) is liberation WHILE LIVING -- the knower of Brahman is free now; the body continues on prarabdha momentum (a spun wheel) until it drops at videhamukti. Liberation is thus a cognitive-existential transformation, not a post-mortem place or reward.

ANALYSIS: For the "robust liberation" stem (2024 Q6(a)): liberation presupposes bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something liberated (a continuity-bearer). Substantial systems make that bearer a soul; Buddhism makes it a stream. So a robust conception needs continuity that can END, not an immortal substance.

BOOK: Paul J. Griffiths (Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion) reads Sankara's moksa as "not acquired but acknowledged": since bondage is only avidya, liberation adds nothing and destroys nothing -- knowledge simply removes an error, and the self is disclosed as having been free all along.

WRONG: Treating kaivalya as a synonym for moksa, or Jain kevala as Samkhya kaivalya. Same syllable, opposite content -- Jain kevala = omniscience; Samkhya kaivalya = contentless isolation. Nyaya apavarga is cessation, not bliss.

Provenance: the §5A bench and the school table are the canonical evidence; keep the seven rows distinct and your script cannot collapse into "all Indian schools seek union with God" -- which is simply false for Nyaya, Samkhya and Buddhism.

Vedantic Atman, Rebirth and Moksa: Advaita versus Visistadvaita

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: The "real agent" question (2022 Q7(b)) is sharp. If Advaita denies ultimate individuality, who is bound and who is liberated? Advaita answers: conventional agency operates until knowledge removes the misidentification; moksa is not the annihilation of an entity but the sublation of a MISTAKEN individuality. Visistadvaita rejects this: the jiva is a real agent throughout, bound by karma and freed into service -- so it has no agent-paradox to solve.

BOOK: Paul J. Griffiths (Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion) locates Sankara's bondage in avidya as a beginningless SUPERIMPOSITION (adhyasa) -- the rope mistaken for a snake -- so moksa is "not acquired but acknowledged". This is the cleanest way to state why, for Advaita, knowledge alone liberates.

ANALYSIS: The role of knowledge (2021 Q6(b)) follows directly: since bondage is ignorance, only knowledge can remove it (darkness by light); devotion and works merely purify (citta-suddhi) and qualify. For Ramanuja knowledge discloses the self as God's mode but culminates in bhakti and grace.

ANALYSIS: The memory objection -- no recollection of prior lives -- is met by distinguishing psychological memory from metaphysical continuity and appealing to latent samskaras; empirical warrant remains contested, so concede it.

Provenance: the Gita garment image is a canonical illustration of embodiment, not an independent demonstration of the eternal self.

Jain Jiva and Bondage: the Karmic-Matter Ladder

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: The 2022 Q8(b) demand is TWO nouns -- "soul AND bondage" -- so deliver both: the jiva metaphysics (eternal, conscious, exactly body-sized during embodiment) AND the asrava/bandha/samvara/nirjara machinery. Missing either half caps the mark.

ANALYSIS: Jain liberation PERFECTS individuality. It is neither Advaitic identity (the soul does not merge into Brahman) nor Buddhist cessation (a real perfected self remains). The freed jiva manifests ananta-catustaya and rises to the summit of the universe.

WRONG: Treating Jain kevala as Samkhya kaivalya. Jain kevala = omniscience (kevala-jnana), the fullest content; Samkhya kaivalya = contentless isolation.

ANALYSIS: The interaction problem: how does non-material consciousness bind with quasi-material karma? Jainism's answer is to treat extension and embodiment as MODES of the jiva during bondage -- consciousness is intrinsically the soul's, and the karmic "matter" is the obscuring medium, not a second substance the soul must reach across. Note this is a concession-shaped reply; flag it as contested.

Provenance: the dust-on-an-oily-body image is the standard canonical illustration of how passions make karma adhere -- use it as a model, not a demonstration.

Cessation and Isolation: Nyaya Apavarga, Advaita Jivanmukti and Samkhya-Yoga Kaivalya

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: Nyaya traces suffering through defect -> activity -> rebirth -> false knowledge; true knowledge reverses the chain, ending pain AND the qualities (including consciousness) that sustain embodied experience. So apavarga is a negative state -- do not call it positive bliss.

ANALYSIS: Advaita's jivanmukti turns on a clean split: liberating knowledge destroys ignorance IMMEDIATELY, but already-fructifying prarabdha karma keeps the body going -- the potter's wheel spins on after the hand withdraws. Hence the objection "if knowledge destroys karma, why does the body remain?" is met by distinguishing accumulated and future karma from prarabdha.

ANALYSIS: Samkhya's most examinable doctrine is SK 62-63: strictly, NO purusa is bound, released or transmigrating; it is prakrti who binds, transmigrates and releases herself. Liberation is viveka-khyati -- discriminative discernment -- correcting a MISATTRIBUTION, not an event in consciousness. SK 67-68 give the potter's-wheel jivanmukti and videha-kaivalya at death.

WRONG: Calling Yoga's Isvara a creator. YS 1.24 makes Isvara a special purusa untouched by karma -- an object of pranidhana, one optional means, not the ground of the world. Yoga is the decisive Indian case of theism without creation.

Provenance: SK 1 (threefold duhkha), 62-63, 67-68 and YS 1.2/1.3/1.24/4.34 are verified numbers; the potter's-wheel image is shared with Advaita but the residue differs (karmic for Advaita, gunas' momentum for Samkhya). Note the parallel and the difference -- that contrast is a top-band discriminator.

Paths to Liberation: Bhakti, and the Jnana-Karma-Bhakti Question

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Bhakti (2018 Q7(c)): loving devotion to a personal God, held to be a DIRECT means and, crucially, open irrespective of caste, gender, language or learning.

ANALYSIS: Its philosophical significance is structural, not emotional: it relocates liberation from ACHIEVEMENT to RECEPTION. If bondage is beginningless, the bound jiva cannot lift itself, so only grace can -- and bhakti is the posture in which grace is received. The marjara-nyaya (cat carries kitten: grace alone) vs markata-nyaya (monkey must cling: grace plus effort) dispute IS the tradition's own statement of the grace-effort problem.

WRONG: Treating bhakti as mere emotion, or saying "Advaita rejects bhakti". Advaita makes bhakti PREPARATORY (citta-suddhi, upasana), qualifying one for jnana -- a difference of role, not of value.

The three-means question (2020 Q8(c)) is decided by a prior question:

ANALYSIS: Is liberation PRODUCED or UNCOVERED? If produced, action can produce it (Mimamsa). If it is the removal of an error, only knowledge removes it -- Sankara's whole case, and why he rejects jnana-karma-samuccaya. Ramanuja accepts a graded samuccaya culminating in bhakti (prapatti as the accessible alternative); Madhva makes knowledge-grounded bhakti decisive under prasada. Deploy saksat-sadhana (direct means) vs arad-upakaraka (remote aid) early.

ANALYSIS: The Gita's own signal (5.4-5) says only the immature call Samkhya and Yoga different, which is why Sankara, Ramanuja and Tilak could each claim the text. They converge in FUNCTION (dismantling egoic appropriation) and diverge in TERMINUS (identity vs communion). Say this rather than harmonising.

BOOK: The nirguna strand (Kabir, Nanak) shows bhakti needs a PERSONAL focus, not an iconic form -- so the "bhakti requires a saguna God" objection is blunted for theists, though it still holds against strictly non-theistic systems.

Provenance: cite Gita 18.66 (carama-sloka), 9.22, 9.32; Bhagavata 7.5.23 (navadha bhakti, nine limbs in order). The Vivekacudamani definition of bhakti is of DISPUTED ascription -- say "the Advaita tradition", never "Sankara wrote".

Resurrection vs Rebirth vs Reincarnation; Inter-School Debates, Criticisms and Traps

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

ANALYSIS: Two Western strands are wrongly merged. Immortality of the soul is Greek/Platonic (soul naturally deathless). Resurrection is Hebrew-Christian-Islamic: the person is a PSYCHOSOMATIC unity, so survival needs God to restore the whole person. Oscar Cullmann (1955) argues the two are theologically OPPOSED, not complementary -- a high-value citation.

BOOK: Lynne Rudder Baker (Oxford Handbook, "Death and the Afterlife") lays out four candidate criteria of personal identity across death -- same soul, same body, same composite (soul + body), or continuity of memory -- and surveys the Christian reassembly tradition: Origen's "seed", Augustine's re-collected "statue", and Aquinas's soul-as-FORM securing bodily continuity.

BOOK: Peter van Inwagen presses the re-assembly ("cannibal") problem -- if atoms are shared between bodies, whose are raised? -- and suggests God preserves a core of the body or substitutes a simulacrum. Bernard Williams's reduplication argument and H. H. Price's "image-world" of the next life both show how fragile the bodily and memory criteria are.

ANALYSIS: John Hick's replica theory answers the identity problem: an exact psychophysical replica, continuous in memory and character, appearing in another space, is the same person for all purposes that matter. Objection: a replica is a duplicate, and God could make TWO; Hick restricts the case to a UNIQUE replica, but critics say the mere possibility of duplication shows the criterion is not identity.

ANALYSIS: For rebirth the identity worry is the memory objection; reply by separating psychological memory from metaphysical continuity (latent samskaras/ vasanas). The gap problem (resurrection) and the memory gap (rebirth) leave the identity question unresolved on BOTH sides -- for opposite reasons.

The canonical criticisms (memory, duplication, moral-desert, liberation-paradox) and the fourteen common traps are preserved verbatim in the CORE slice above -- the answer-spine visual is the fast retrieval key to them.

Provenance: Hick replica theory, Cullmann 1955, and van Inwagen on resurrection are verified attributions; the Gita 2.22 garment and 9.21 pitryana verses are verified.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - Soul: Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation

Last-mile retrieval sheet. It condenses all ten subtopics, the provenance ledger, the 17-part PYQ routing, the keyword bank, the fourteen traps and the answer spine. Read after the teaching and the solved practice, never instead of them.

A. The Six Survival-Terms (never merge)

- **Immortality** = the soul does not die with the body (Plato; Indian eternal self).
- **Survival** = something of me continues after death (the generic claim).
- **Rebirth** = karmically driven re-becoming; the WIDER, neutral term.
- **Reincarnation** = a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-enfleshed (Vedanta, Nyaya, Jain).
- **Resurrection** = one life; God re-constitutes the whole embodied person.
- **Liberation** = exit from the cycle; a FAMILY term (moksa / apavarga / kaivalya / nirvana / kevala).
- **Modal spine**: immortality of a substantial soul is SUFFICIENT for rebirth, not NECESSARY (Buddhism). What rebirth needs is a continuity-bearer.

B. Immortality - Plato and the West

- Four Phaedo proofs: **Opposites** (cyclical), **Recollection** (pre-existence), **Affinity** (simple, akin to the Forms), **Form of Life** (cannot admit death).
- Bridge: recollection/opposites give only PRE-existence, not survival.
- Critique: simplicity does not entail indestructibility; Kant's paralogism -- the soul is not a knowable substance. Simmias' harmony objection; Plato: soul rules body.
- Baker (Oxford Handbook): Plato = NATURAL immortality; Semitic = survival by divine ACT.

C. Rebirth, Karma, Samsara

- Karma = act + unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*); **sancita / prarabdha / agami**.
- Rebirth = the field where fruits maturing beyond one life are discharged.
- Not fatalism: **purusakara** works within **daiva**. Subtle body carries *samskaras*.
- Verified verses: *Gita* 2.22 (garments), 9.21 (return from heaven).

D. Buddhist Continuity Without a Soul

- **anatman + pratityasamutpada**: rebirth = a causal STREAM, not a traveller.
- Models: flame-to-flame, milk-to-curd (continuity, not identity).
- "Neither the same nor wholly other" answers who-reaps-the-fruit.
- anatman is not nihilism. Quinn (Oxford Handbook): nirvana = ceasing-to-be of the individual self, contrasted with Christian union-with-God. 2018 = significance of the anti-theistic stand.

E. Liberation Parity Bench (seven destinations)

Term	School	What ends	Consciousness
moksa	Advaita	avidya	non-dual bliss
moksa	Visistadvaita	karmic bondage	personal, communion
apavarga	Nyaya-Vaisesika	pain + its causes	NONE
kaivalya	Samkhya-Yoga	aviveka	pure, contentless
kevala/siddhatva	Jainism	karmic matter	omniscient
nirvana	Buddhism	craving, dukkha	no self stated
resurrection	Semitic	death	embodied, before God

- **jivanmukti** (free while living; body on *prarabdha*) vs **videhamukti** (at death).
- Griffiths: Advaitic moksa "not acquired but acknowledged".

F. Vedanta - Advaita vs Visistadvaita

- Advaita: *atman* = Brahman; bondage = *avidya/adhyasa*; means = *jnana*;
liberation = identity; individuality sublated (not annihilated).
- Visistadvaita: *jiva* = eternal mode of God; means = *bhakti* + *prapatti*, by grace;
liberation = communion; *jiva* persists.
- The "real agent" problem is Advaita's to solve (conventional agency until insight).

G. Jain Jiva and Bondage Ladder

- *jiva* = eternal, conscious, body-sized; intrinsic **ananta-catustaya**.
- **asrava** (influx) -> **bandha** (bondage) -> **samvara** (stoppage) -> **nirjara** (shedding) -> **kevala/siddhatva** (perfected, rises to universe-top).
- Interaction problem: extension/embodiment are MODES of *jiva* during bondage (contested).
- Jain *kevala* = omniscience (NOT Samkhya's contentless *kaivalya*).

H. Cessation and Isolation - Apavarga, Jivanmukti, Kaivalya

- Nyaya **apavarga** = cessation of pain AND consciousness (adventitious consciousness).
- Advaita **jivanmukti** = knowledge frees now; *prarabdha* coasts the body (spun wheel).
- Samkhya **kaivalya** = isolation of *purusa*; **SK 62-63** = *prakrti* binds/releases, not *purusa*; **SK 67-68** potter's wheel + *videha-kaivalya*.
- **YS 1.24** = Isvara is a special *purusa*, not a creator (theism without creation).

I. Paths - Bhakti and the Three Means

- **Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jnana removes** - three means of different kinds.
- Production vs removal model decides the DIRECT means; *saksat-sadhana* vs *arad-upakaraka*.
- Sankara rejects *jnana-karma-samuccaya*; Ramanuja accepts a graded one -> *bhakti*; Mimamsa = karma alone; *Gita* 5.4-5 = convergence (function, not terminus).
- **marjara** (grace alone) vs **markata** (grace + effort). *Vivekacudamani* ascription
DISPUTED -> "the Advaita tradition".
- Verified: *Gita* 18.66, 9.22, 9.32; *Bhagavata* 7.5.23 (nine limbs).

J. Resurrection vs Rebirth vs Reincarnation

- Resurrection = one life, psychosomatic person, divine act, judgement (Cullmann 1955: opposed to immortality).
- Rebirth (wider) vs reincarnation (assumes a substance; wrong for Buddhism).
- Identity replies: Aquinas (soul = form), van Inwagen (core preserved / simulacrum),

Hick (unique replica) + duplication objection. Rebirth: memory != continuity.

- Baker's four criteria; Origen "seed" / Augustine "statue"; Williams reduplication;

Price image-world.

K. Provenance Ledger (use only these)

- *Gita* 2.22, 2.23, 5.4-5, 9.21, 9.22, 9.32, 18.66. *Bhagavata* 7.5.23.
- *Samkhya-karika* 1, 62-63, 67-68. *Yoga-sutra* 1.2, 1.3, 1.24, 2.3, 4.29, 4.34.
- Hick replica theory; Cullmann 1955; van Inwagen on resurrection.
- Flame-to-flame / milk-to-curd = illustrations, never proofs.
- Disputed: *Vivekacudamani* ascription to Sankara -- flag, do not assert.

L. 17-Part PYQ Routing (2018-2025)

Year	Q	Marks	Owner theme
2018	Q5(b)	10	anti-theistic religions' stand on rebirth
2018	Q7(c)	15	Bhakti as a pathway to liberation
2019	Q8(a)	20	Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation
2020	Q5(b)	10	'Immortality' as presupposition of religion
2020	Q8(c)	15	Knowledge, Action, Devotion as means
2021	Q6(a)	20	immortality of soul w.r.t. Hindu tradition
2021	Q6(b)	15	Advaita liberation + role of knowledge
2021	Q8(b)	15	Karma as an essential postulate
2022	Q5(c)	10	immortality necessary for rebirth (Buddhism)
2022	Q7(b)	15	liberation without a real agent (Advaita/Visistadvaita)
2022	Q8(b)	15	Soul and Bondage in Jainism
2023	Q6(a)	20	Plato's apriori proofs
2023	Q7(b)	15	rebirth in the theory of Karma
2024	Q5(c)	10	apavarga in Nyaya-Vaisesika
2024	Q6(a)	20	immortality + rebirth for robust liberation
2025	Q5(d)	10	jivanmukti in Advaita Vedanta
2025	Q7(c)	15	immortality necessary for rebirth (Gita)

- Distribution 2:1:2:3:3:2:2:2 = 17 owner parts. Indian Philosophy Paper I moksa/soul

questions are NOT counted here.

M. Keyword and Statement Bank

- **Keywords:** immortality, pre-existence, recollection, affinity, Form of Life,

resurrection, psychosomatic unity, replica, gap problem, re-assembly, atman, jiva, subtle body, karma, samsara, punarjanma, punarbhava, reincarnation vs rebirth, anatman, pratityasamutpada, samskara/vasana, apavarga, moksa, nirvana, kaivalya, kevala-jnana, jivanmukti, videhamukti, prarabdha, samvara, nirjara, bhakti, navadha bhakti, vaidhi/raganuga, saguna/nirguna, prapatti/saranagati, marjara/markata, aviveka, viveka-khyati, satkaryavada, niskama-karma, saksat-sadhana/arad-upakaraka.

- **Safe formulations:** "Rebirth needs continuity, not necessarily an immortal

substance." | "Liberation is a family-resemblance term." | "Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jnana removes." | "Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions."

N. Fourteen Common Traps (one line each)

1. Do not equate immortality, resurrection and rebirth.
2. Buddhism denies permanent substance-self, not continuity.
3. Nyaya apavarga is not positive bliss.
4. Not all Indian liberation is merger with God.
5. The flame analogy illustrates, it does not prove.
6. In jivanmukti separate knowledge (frees) from prarabdha (sustains body).
7. Bhakti is not mere emotion; it shifts achievement -> reception.
8. Advaita makes bhakti preparatory, not rejected.
9. Do not say "all three means are equal"; name the disagreement.
10. Rebirth is not reincarnation (substance vs wider term).
11. Resurrection is not rebirth in heaven.
12. kaivalya (Samkhya isolation) is not kevala (Jain omniscience).
13. Yoga's Isvara (YS 1.24) is not a creator.
14. Samkhya's purusa is not bound/released -- prakrti is (SK 62-63).

O. Answer Spine (objection -> reply)

- memory gap -> memory is not metaphysical continuity; latent *samskaras*.
- duplication -> substance theory keeps one bearer; Buddhism drops numerical identity.
- moral desert -> karma explains distribution, does not license social blame.
- who seeks moksha? -> conventional agency operates until insight removes the error.
- replica = a copy? -> Hick restricts to a UNIQUE replica meeting our criteria.
- re-assembly -> Aquinas (soul = form) / van Inwagen (God keeps a core).
- resurrection = rebirth? -> no: one life, divine act, final judgement.

MEMORY: When a stem names a liberation-term, FIRST fix it on the parity bench (E). Half the marks in this clause are lost to term-merging.